

Teaching Portfolio

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PART 1

Teaching Statement

Teaching philosophy and pedagogical approach.

Teaching Statement

Teaching Objectives

As a philosophy teacher, my main goals are to help students (1) **achieve clarity and analyticity in writing and in oral discussion**, and (2) **engage in the activity of philosophy**. I believe that both (1) and (2) are valuable no matter whether a student ends up pursuing academic philosophy or not.

(1) is a skill that is most emphasized in contemporary philosophy writing. The ability to write and speak clearly and logically is valuable for all future pursuits of the student.

(2) reflects my own perspective about what philosophy and liberal arts education are about. **Philosophy for me is an activity like hiking**. Existing literature serves as guidance for future hikers. What really matters is for students to engage in the activity itself.

Unlike hiking, there is more danger in philosophy. This is why students need guidance from literature and from teachers to obtain necessary skills and knowledge to practice philosophy safely and well. Once these basics are at place, I try my best to invite students to engage in the activity, thinking for themselves, asking their own question, etc.

When teaching **general education courses**, I try to encourage students to think about fundamental topics like identity, good life or good society, which I believe that every member of society can benefit from. I try to maximize engagement instead of comprehensiveness. I believe that it is what an educator can actually contribute to society, not to teach ten different theories of justice, but to **pass along a sense of justice**.

When teaching **high-level courses** for major students, I try to be focused on specific topics, encouraging students to be as careful as they can. In this way, they can develop relevant skills for future pursuits in developing good philosophy. **Depth is the focus** in this case.

Course Design

My teaching is informed by **both historical and contemporary philosophy**. I'd like to organize my courses **thematically with conceptual narratives** while using key contemporary and historical figures and writings as examples. Philosophy in my view is composed of questions. History is helpful as in it gives you the opportunity to see how good philosophers of our time and in the past approach those questions.

Contemporary writings share similar socio-historical background with us and **are easier for students to understand**. **Historical writings**, in contrast, are more difficult for students to process but **can open conceptual possibilities**. An example I often use is Nietzsche's

Perfectionism and MaxiMax principle of distribution, which challenges the basic sense of equality common of our time. This is why I often find it helpful have students **read history backwards**. First let them read contemporary writings to motivate the general philosophical question and then go back in history and see other possibilities.

For me, **history** of philosophy ultimately **serves** for **our purpose of doing philosophy**. Yet, it's valuable to gain authentic understanding of historical figures, while recognizing that interpretation is always imperfect and historically situated. So that, we do not miss the valuable lesson of the history and end up reading ourselves from them.

Class Engagement

In my experience, students are more willing to engage if you show that you are prepared and care about their learning. Besides, I find the practice of **prepared cold calling** very helpful.

To encourage engagement, at the end of each class, I would give students some *simple* questions about readings for the next class and told them explicitly that I will cold call on these questions. The questions are designed to be simple and answerable if a student spends about 15 minutes on the reading. In this way, I encourage more students to at least have some exposure to the readings ahead of class.

Assessments

I hope to help students develop their philosophical skills gradually via assessments. In lower-level courses, I assign **short analytic writing exercises** that focus on clarity, structure, and argumentative precision. For example, students might be asked to reconstruct a short argument, identify a hidden assumption, explain the difference between two claims, formulate an objection, or revise a paragraph to make its thesis clearer. These assignments help students see that philosophical writing is not primarily a matter of expressing a personal opinion, but of making a claim intelligible and answerable to reasons. Short assignments also make it easier to give **targeted feedback** on specific skills before students are asked to write longer papers.

In upper-level courses, I ask students to write longer and more independent papers, but I continue to provide **structure and guidance**. I want students to experience the process of developing a philosophical project: finding a question, formulating a thesis, reconstructing a debate, considering objections, and revising in light of feedback. Whenever possible, I incorporate staged assignments, such as paper proposals, outlines, draft introductions, peer comments, or revision plans. This scaffolding helps students understand that good philosophical writing rarely appears all at once. It is produced through clarification, pressure, and revision.

Teaching Experience

Courses Taught as Teaching Assistant:

Concepts of Human Nature, University of Pittsburgh, 2020

- 3 sections, 20 students per section
- This course reads selected writings by Plato, Hobbes, Rousseau, Marx and Freud, with a focus on different conceptions of human nature.

History of Modern Philosophy, University of Pittsburgh, 2021

- 3 sections, 20 students per section
- This course reads selected writings by Descartes, Locke, Hume and Kant, with a focus on epistemology.

Intermediate Logic, Australian National University, 2017

- 1 section of 30 students from Philosophy and Computer Science
- This course covers the semantics and syntax of propositional and first-order logic, with an emphasis on proofs and Logic Programming.

Guest Lectures:

- **Causation, Causal Direction and Causal Discovery**, 3 lectures, University of Chinese Academy of Sciences, Beijing, China
- **Induction and Causation in Science**, 2 lectures, Central University of Finance and Economics, Beijing, China
- **Science and Society**, 5 lectures, Veritas China, a student-organized NPO for liberal art education
- **Equality in Contemporary Political Philosophy: Utilitarianism and Rawls**, 1 online lecture

PART 2

Future Teaching Plan

Four sample syllabi for future teaching.

Future Teaching Plans

I include four sample syllabi below for reference:

Scientific Methodology: Measurement, Experiments, and Inference

An upper-level undergraduate or introductory graduate course on how measurement, experimental design, and statistical inference jointly support scientific claims. Students examine theory-dependent measurement, debates over randomized trials and causal inference, and frequentist and Bayesian accounts of evidence, then integrate these components in an analysis of a scientific study.

Philosophy of Machine Learning: Induction, Generalization, and Artificial Inquiry

An upper-level undergraduate or introductory graduate course on the epistemology of machine learning. Students connect problems of induction and generalization to questions about inductive bias, learnability, calibration, representation, and interpretability. Later units examine distribution shift, foundation models, and the collective consequences of reliance on shared AI systems.

AI and Society

An upper-level undergraduate course that introduces students to social issues related to AI. Topics include algorithmic bias and fairness, AI governance, philosophical theories of justice, and the social epistemic and distributional effects of AI.

Introduction to Ethics

An introductory undergraduate course on ethics with a focus on the relation between the good and the right. Topics include utilitarianism, Kantian ethics, virtue ethics, theories of the good, theories of the right, and the question of why we should be moral.

I'm also happy to teach other courses in my AOS and AOC.

AOS: Philosophy of AI, Social Epistemology, Game Theory, Decision Theory, Justice, Philosophy of Economics, Philosophy of Statistics, Logic

AOC: General Philosophy of Science, History of Modern Philosophy, Ethics

To name a few courses:

A course on **Epistemology** with a historical focus on the debate between foundationalism and coherentism (cf. BonJour, *Epistemology: Classic Problems and Contemporary Responses*).

A course on the **History of Modern Philosophy** based on readings from Descartes, Locke, Hume, and Kant, with a focus on epistemology and its connection to the development of modern science.

A course on **Philosophy of Science** with a historical focus on the Scientific Revolution and later developments, drawing on Galileo, Newton, and Lavoisier, and a theoretical focus on scientific paradigms and methodology.

A course on **Game Theory** with an emphasis on the applicability and limits of different solution concepts, with applications to social epistemology, philosophy of science, and ethics.

A course on **Group Decision**, covering both epistemic aspects (epistemic aggregation) and preference-related aspects (social choice).

Scientific Methodology

Measurement, Experiments, and Inference

Yao Fan | Sample syllabus | Advanced undergraduate / junior graduate seminar | 13 weeks

Course description

Scientists infer properties and causes that cannot simply be read from observations. The warrant for these inferences depends on what is measured, how a study is designed, and how its results are interpreted. This course examines the assumptions connecting these stages and asks how they can be tested.

Three sustained units organize the course. Measurement investigates whether operational definitions and theory-dependent procedures capture their intended properties, using temperature, planetary mass, and psychological tests. Experimental design examines the causal warrant of randomized trials, observational comparisons, and extrapolation to new settings. Statistical inference compares frequentist and Bayesian accounts of evidence before considering how the consequences of error affect evidential standards. The Salk vaccine trial recurs across the design and inference units, allowing students to assess how these components jointly support a scientific claim.

Learning objectives

- Reconstruct and evaluate the assumptions linking observations to measured quantities and causal claims.
- Compare frequentist and Bayesian accounts of evidence, distinguishing statistical uncertainty from questions about measurement, causal identification, and generalization.
- Defend a reconstruction or redesign of a scientific study that integrates measurement, design, and inference.

Teaching and assessment

Seminars pair philosophical disputes with guided exercises: comparing thermometers, reconstructing planetary mass ratios, evaluating trial designs, and interpreting the same data under competing statistical approaches. Unit assignments develop toward a final paper or methodology portfolio.

Requirement	Weight	Purpose
Participation	15%	Prepared discussion and engagement with competing arguments.
Reading and practice notes	15%	Eight brief notes connecting a philosophical claim to a scientific case.
Three unit assignments	20%	Measurement audit (Week 4), study design (Week 8), and inferential comparison (Week 11); equally weighted.
Study presentation	10%	Reconstruct the assumptions supporting a published empirical claim.
Final paper or portfolio	40%	Integrate all three components in an argument or defended study redesign (Week 13).

Preparation Elementary algebra and basic probability; no calculus or programming required. Prior study in philosophy of science or a related discipline is recommended.

Reading approach Readings are assigned in guided excerpts. For Week 3, Poincaré runs from “The Law of Acceleration” through the end of chapter VI. Friedman’s “Theory-Mediated Measurement and Newtonian Methodology” (2023), especially pp. 245–251, is optional further reading.

Weekly schedule

The three units build toward an integrated assessment of scientific evidence. Readings below identify the core selections.

Wk	Topic and guiding question	Selected readings
I Measurement <i>What warrants trusting a measure?</i>		
1	Operational definitions Does defining a procedure establish what it measures?	Tal, "Measurement in Science"; Chang, "Operationalism"
2	Temperature and calibration How can we justify a standard without assuming its accuracy?	Chang, Inventing Temperature; Tal on calibration
3	Newton and planetary masses How can theory-dependent measurements help test the theory?	Poincaré, Science and Hypothesis, ch. VI; Smith, "Newton's Principia," §10
4	Psychological validity Does a reliable and predictive test measure its intended attribute?	Borsboom et al., "The Concept of Validity"; Chang
II Experimental design <i>What warrants a causal comparison?</i>		
5	Controls and counterfactuals What distinguishes a treatment effect from a pre-existing difference?	Holland, "Statistics and Causal Inference"; Freedman et al.
6	Randomized trials What does random assignment establish, and what remains assumed?	Deaton and Cartwright on RCTs; Imbens's response
7	Observational evidence When can background knowledge justify a causal comparison?	Hernán and Robins, Causal Inference; Woodward on interventions
8	External validity Why should a result obtained here apply somewhere else?	Cartwright and Hardie, Evidence-Based Policy; Freedman et al.
III Statistical inference <i>What conclusions does the evidence warrant?</i>		
9	Frequentist evidence Why should long-run error control matter for this inference?	Wasserstein and Lazar on p-values; Mayo on severe testing
10	Bayesian evidence How should prior beliefs shape what we learn from data?	Stone, Bayes' Rule, ch. 1; Romeijn, "Philosophy of Statistics"
11	Interpreting a trial How do statistical evidence and causal assumptions work together?	Romeijn on stopping rules; revisit the RCT debate
12	Inductive risk Should the costs of error affect evidential standards?	Rudner on value judgments; Douglas on inductive risk
Synthesis <i>How do the three components support a scientific claim?</i>		
13	Reconstructing scientific warrant How should we assess a study when its methods depend on one another?	Final projects and presentations; review selected course readings

Selected readings and seminar activities

The selections below develop the disputes outlined in the schedule. Readings are assigned in guided excerpts, with scientific examples introduced through diagrams and elementary calculations.

I Measurement

Weeks 1–4 ask whether operational definitions suffice to establish what a procedure measures, and how theoretical assumptions and further evidence can support or undermine that claim.

- **Week 1** Eran Tal, “Measurement in Science,” introduction and sections on operationalism and scales; Hasok Chang, “Operationalism,” §§1.2 and 2.1. Both are in the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy.
- **Week 2** Chang, *Inventing Temperature* (2004), narrative selections from chapters 1–2 and epistemic iteration in chapter 5; Tal on calibration and measurement uncertainty.
- **Week 3** Poincaré, *Science and Hypothesis*, chapter VI, from “The Law of Acceleration” to the end; companion reading: George E. Smith, “Newton’s *Philosophiae Naturalis Principia Mathematica*,” §10, selected paragraphs on methodology.
- **Week 4** Denny Borsboom, Gideon J. Mellenbergh, and Jaap van Heerden, “The Concept of Validity” (2004); Chang, “Operationalism,” §3.4.

Seminar activities Compare thermometers that agree at calibration points but disagree elsewhere. Use a guided handout on Newton’s *Principia*, Book III, Proposition VIII and Corollaries 1–2, to infer relative planetary masses from satellite periods and distances. Identify the simplifying assumptions and further observations that could test the result. Apply these lessons to the validity of a psychological questionnaire.

Optional extension Michael Friedman, “Theory-Mediated Measurement and Newtonian Methodology” (2023), especially pp. 245–251; Smith, §4, on Newton’s definitions.

II Experimental design

Weeks 5–8 examine the warrant for causal comparisons. Randomized trials anchor a dispute about what design establishes, which assumptions remain, and when findings can travel to new settings.

- **Week 5** Paul W. Holland, “Statistics and Causal Inference” (1986), passages on potential outcomes and the fundamental problem of causal inference; Freedman, Pisani, and Purves, *Statistics*, on controlled experiments and the Salk vaccine trial.
- **Week 6** Angus Deaton and Nancy Cartwright, “Understanding and Misunderstanding Randomized Controlled Trials” (2018), selections on randomization and balance; Guido W. Imbens’s commentary (2018).
- **Week 7** Miguel A. Hernán and James M. Robins, *Causal Inference: What If* (2020), selections from chapters 3 and 7; James Woodward, “Causation and Manipulability,” on interventions.
- **Week 8** Nancy Cartwright and Jeremy Hardie, *Evidence-Based Policy* (2012), on moving from “it worked there” to “it will work here”; Freedman, Pisani, and Purves on sampling and surveys.

Seminar activities Compare before–after, self-selected, and randomized treatment groups. Repeat random assignments to observe chance imbalance, then assess the critics’ and defenders’ arguments. Draw rival causal diagrams for an observational study and evaluate whether a successful intervention should transfer to another population.

Inference and integration

III Statistical inference

Weeks 9–12 compare accounts of evidential warrant. The guiding dispute concerns the roles of error control, prior information, and the consequences of error in supporting scientific conclusions.

- **Week 9** Ronald L. Wasserstein and Nicole A. Lazar, “The ASA’s Statement on p-Values: Context, Process, and Purpose” (2016); Deborah G. Mayo, *Error and the Growth of Experimental Knowledge* (1996), introductory selections on severe testing.
- **Week 10** James V. Stone, *Bayes’ Rule: A Tutorial Introduction to Bayesian Analysis* (2013), chapter 1; Jan-Willem Romeijn, “Philosophy of Statistics,” sections on Bayesian inference and priors.
- **Week 11** Romeijn on the likelihood principle and stopping rules; revisit Deaton and Cartwright and Imbens. Apply frequentist and Bayesian approaches to the same simplified trial results.
- **Week 12** Richard Rudner, “The Scientist Qua Scientist Makes Value Judgments” (1953); Heather Douglas, “Inductive Risk and Values in Science” (2000), selected argument and examples.

Seminar activities Use repeated-trial simulations to interpret confidence intervals, then update probabilities under two different priors. Write competing interpretations of one trial and distinguish statistical uncertainty from questions about measurement, compliance, and causal identification. Finally, compare decisions with different costs of error while keeping the evidence fixed.

Synthesis

Week 13 Present and discuss final reconstructions or redesigns. Return to Newton and the trial case to assess how theoretical assumptions, control, and error checking work together. Students review readings relevant to their projects; no new core reading is assigned.

Assignment sequence

The three unit assignments may become parts of the final project. Each requires a defended methodological judgment, explicit assumptions, and consideration of a plausible objection.

Week 4 Measurement audit Identify a target property, the observations used to measure it, theoretical assumptions, a validation strategy, and one important possible source of error.

Week 5 Project proposal Choose a published study or focused methodological question and identify its central philosophical problem. Develop an annotated bibliography by Week 8.

Week 8 Study design Specify a causal question, outcome measure, comparison, and target population. Defend the design against an alternative and explain its main limitation.

Week 11 Inferential comparison Compare frequentist and Bayesian interpretations of the same trial results. Explain where they differ and identify assumptions that both require.

Weeks 8–13 Study presentation Give a 15-minute reconstruction of a published empirical claim and use discussion to refine the final project.

Week 13 Final paper or portfolio Integrate measurement, design, and inference in a sustained analysis or defended redesign. Undergraduates submit 12–15 pages; graduate students submit 18–25 pages, or an equivalent portfolio. Graduate work engages additional literature and a substantial objection.

Philosophy of Machine Learning

Induction, Generalization, and Artificial Inquiry

Advanced Undergraduate / Junior Graduate Seminar | 13 Weeks

Instructor	Email	Office Hours	Meeting Time
[Name]	[Email]	[Time / Location]	[Days / Time / Room]

Course Description

This course studies machine learning from inside the practice of machine learning. Students learn enough of the technical vocabulary and formal structure of supervised learning to understand why training, validation, generalization, regularization, calibration, representation, and distribution shift generate philosophical problems. The central question is simple: why should success on finite training data justify expectations about unseen cases? That question connects modern machine learning to Hume on induction and Goodman on projectability, but the course does not treat ML merely as an illustration of old philosophical puzzles. Contemporary ML phenomena - underspecification, overfitting, learned representations, benchmark dependence, uncertainty miscalibration, distribution shift, foundation models, and algorithmic monoculture - also create new problems about what counts as reliable artificial inquiry.

COURSE DESIGN RATIONALE

The course is ML-first and philosophy-integrated. Each unit begins with a recognizable machine-learning practice, formal result, or failure mode and then asks what epistemic assumptions make it work. Classical epistemology enters where it illuminates a technical problem: Hume through generalization, Goodman through inductive bias and underspecification, Bayesian epistemology through uncertainty, and philosophy of explanation through interpretability. Formal learning theory is used to clarify what generalization guarantees do and do not establish. Later weeks move from individual models to deployment and shared AI systems, showing how epistemic evaluation changes when training distributions shift or many agents depend on the same model.

Course Architecture

Part of the ML Pipeline	Machine-Learning Question	Philosophical Question
Task and data	What are the inputs, labels, targets, and loss?	What is the learner being asked to learn, and which choices already encode inductive assumptions?
Training	Which model minimizes the objective on observed data?	Why should optimization on this sample track anything beyond the sample?
Validation	How well does the model perform on held-out cases?	What licenses generalization, and what assumptions do the guarantees require?
Representation and uncertainty	What features does the model use, and how confident is it?	Which regularities are projectable, and when should numerical confidence be trusted?
Deployment and ecosystem	How does the system behave under shift and shared use?	How do environmental change and correlated dependence alter epistemic reliability?

Learning Objectives

- Explain the basic structure of supervised machine learning, including training, validation, loss, empirical risk, and generalization.

Philosophy of Machine Learning

- Connect Humean induction and Goodman-style projectability to concrete ML problems such as generalization, inductive bias, and underspecification.
- Work through elementary examples of overfitting, regularization, PAC learning, VC dimension, Bayesian prediction, and calibration.
- Evaluate representation learning, interpretability, and distribution shift using both technical evidence and philosophical argument.
- Analyze foundation models and shared ML systems as epistemic technologies whose reliability depends on deployment context and social dependence.

Prerequisites and Course Format

Prerequisites: One prior course in logic, epistemology, philosophy of science, statistics, cognitive science, computer science, or a related field is recommended. Students should be comfortable with elementary algebra and basic probability. No programming background is assumed. Small computational demonstrations use instructor-provided notebooks so that students can inspect model behavior without needing to build software from scratch.

Course Requirements and Assessment

Requirement	Weight	Description
Participation and seminar citizenship	15%	Regular attendance, careful preparation, constructive discussion, and respectful engagement with peers.
Reading and model notes	15%	Eight brief notes that connect a technical ML result, failure mode, or modeling choice to a philosophical question.
Formal and computational exercises	20%	Four short exercises on train-test generalization; ERM/overfitting; PAC/VC-style learnability; and calibration, shift, or correlated-error examples. Instructor-provided notebooks may be used.
ML paper presentation	10%	A 15-minute presentation explaining one machine-learning paper or method to a philosophical audience, followed by a reconstruction of its epistemic assumptions.
Final paper or model-epistemology portfolio	40%	A 12-15 page paper for undergraduates or 18-25 page paper for graduate students, or an equivalent portfolio analyzing the epistemology of a concrete ML pipeline or phenomenon. A proposal and annotated bibliography are due before the final version.

SIGNATURE FINAL PROJECT

Students select a concrete ML phenomenon - for example overfitting, calibration, representation learning, dataset shift, interpretability, foundation-model transfer, or algorithmic monoculture - and analyze both how the ML method works and what epistemic claim it can support. A portfolio option combines a small model or notebook analysis with a philosophical essay explaining which assumptions, guarantees, and failure modes matter.

Required and Recommended Materials

Required readings will be made available through the course site or library reserves. The course draws especially on the following books and articles:

Philosophy of Machine Learning

- Shai Shalev-Shwartz and Shai Ben-David, Understanding Machine Learning: From Theory to Algorithms, selected chapters.
- Tom M. Mitchell, Machine Learning, introductory selections.
- Gilbert Harman and Sanjeev Kulkarni, Reliable Reasoning: Induction and Statistical Learning Theory, selections.
- Nelson Goodman, Fact, Fiction, and Forecast, selections.
- Alexander D'Amour et al., "Underspecification Presents Challenges for Credibility in Modern Machine Learning."
- Yoshua Bengio, Aaron Courville, and Pascal Vincent, "Representation Learning: A Review and New Perspectives."
- Zachary C. Lipton, "The Mythos of Model Interpretability."
- Rishi Bommasani et al., "On the Opportunities and Risks of Foundation Models," selections.
- Jon Kleinberg and Manish Raghavan, "Algorithmic Monoculture and Social Welfare."

Recommended background: Ian Goodfellow, Yoshua Bengio, and Aaron Courville, Deep Learning; David MacKay, Information Theory, Inference, and Learning Algorithms; Vladimir Vapnik, The Nature of Statistical Learning Theory; Kevin T. Kelly, The Logic of Reliable Inquiry; and selected contemporary papers on calibration, distribution shift, robustness, interpretability, and human-AI systems.

Detailed Weekly Schedule

Week 1: Anatomy of a Machine-Learning System

Guiding question: What, exactly, is being learned when a model is trained on data?

Practice focus: Trace a simple supervised-learning pipeline from task definition and labeled data through model class, loss, training, validation, and prediction.

Required readings:

- Tom M. Mitchell, Machine Learning, ch. 1.
- Shai Shalev-Shwartz and Shai Ben-David, Understanding Machine Learning: From Theory to Algorithms, ch. 1, "A Gentle Start."
- Optional: Ian Goodfellow, Yoshua Bengio, and Aaron Courville, Deep Learning, ch. 1 selections.

Key concepts: supervised learning; training data; labels; hypothesis class; loss; optimization; prediction; evaluation.

Week 2: Train, Test, and the Problem of Generalization

Guiding question: Why should success on observed data imply success on cases the model has never seen?

Practice focus: Separate training, validation, and test performance in a small classification example; compare ordinary test-set success with performance on a newly constructed test set.

Required readings:

- Shalev-Shwartz and Ben-David, Understanding Machine Learning, chs. 2-3 selections.
- David Hume, An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding, Section IV.
- Benjamin Recht, Rebecca Roelofs, Ludwig Schmidt, and Vaishaal Shankar, "Do ImageNet Classifiers Generalize to ImageNet?" selections.

Key concepts: training error; test error; generalization gap; iid assumption; induction; distribution; benchmark; unseen cases.

Week 3: Inductive Bias, Projectability, and Underspecification

Guiding question: How can many models fit the same evidence yet behave differently when deployed?

Practice focus: Compare models that achieve similar validation performance but rely on different features; use stress tests to expose underspecification.

Required readings:

- Nelson Goodman, Fact, Fiction, and Forecast, selections on the new riddle of induction.

Philosophy of Machine Learning

- Alexander D'Amour et al., "Underspecification Presents Challenges for Credibility in Modern Machine Learning," selections.
- Pedro Domingos, "A Few Useful Things to Know about Machine Learning," selections.

Key concepts: projectability; inductive bias; underdetermination; underspecification; shortcut learning; validation criterion; stress testing.

Week 4: Learning as Risk Minimization

Guiding question: What epistemic goal is encoded when learning is defined as minimizing a loss function?

Practice focus: Compute empirical risk for competing predictors under different losses and examine how changing the objective changes the preferred model.

Required readings:

- Shalev-Shwartz and Ben-David, Understanding Machine Learning, selections on empirical risk minimization.
- Gilbert Harman and Sanjeev Kulkarni, Reliable Reasoning: Induction and Statistical Learning Theory, selections.
- Optional: Leo Breiman, "Statistical Modeling: The Two Cultures," opening sections.

Key concepts: loss function; empirical risk; true risk; ERM; optimization; objective choice; prediction versus inference.

Week 5: Overfitting, Regularization, and Model Selection

Guiding question: How should a learner trade fit to the observed sample against simplicity, stability, and future performance?

Practice focus: Fit increasingly flexible models to the same toy dataset and compare training error, validation error, cross-validation, and regularized solutions.

Required readings:

- Shalev-Shwartz and Ben-David, Understanding Machine Learning, selections on overfitting, regularization, and model selection.
- Pedro Domingos, "A Few Useful Things to Know about Machine Learning," review selections.
- Optional: instructor-provided selections on cross-validation and the bias-variance tradeoff.

Key concepts: overfitting; underfitting; regularization; hyperparameter; cross-validation; complexity; bias-variance tradeoff.

Week 6: PAC Learning, VC Dimension, and Learnability

Guiding question: What does it mean to have a mathematical guarantee that a class of models can learn from finite data?

Practice focus: Work through simple hypothesis classes and sample-complexity examples; distinguish a conditional generalization theorem from a universal solution to induction.

Required readings:

- Shalev-Shwartz and Ben-David, Understanding Machine Learning, selections on PAC learning and VC dimension.
- Harman and Kulkarni, Reliable Reasoning, selections on statistical learning theory.
- Optional: Vladimir Vapnik, The Nature of Statistical Learning Theory, introductory selections.

Key concepts: PAC learning; VC dimension; uniform convergence; sample complexity; learnability; generalization bound; assumptions.

Week 7: Bayesian Learning, Confidence, and Calibration

Guiding question: When should a model's numerical confidence be treated as rational uncertainty?

Practice focus: Compare predicted probabilities with empirical frequencies; apply a simple calibration transformation and distinguish posterior uncertainty from calibrated predictive confidence.

Required readings:

- David MacKay, Information Theory, Inference, and Learning Algorithms, selections on Bayesian learning.
- Chuan Guo, Geoff Pleiss, Yu Sun, and Kilian Q. Weinberger, "On Calibration of Modern Neural Networks."
- Optional: Michael G. Titelbaum, Fundamentals of Bayesian Epistemology, selections on updating.

Philosophy of Machine Learning

Key concepts: prior; likelihood; posterior predictive; predictive probability; calibration; confidence; uncertainty quantification.

Week 8: Representation Learning and Learned Features

Guiding question: How does a model's representation of the data determine what patterns are easy or difficult to learn?

Practice focus: Compare raw features with learned representations and examine how representation changes separability, transfer, and what regularities become salient.

Required readings:

- Yoshua Bengio, Aaron Courville, and Pascal Vincent, "Representation Learning: A Review and New Perspectives," selections.
- Goodfellow, Bengio, and Courville, Deep Learning, selections on representation learning.
- Optional: Goodman, Fact, Fiction, and Forecast, brief review selections on predicates and projectability.

Key concepts: feature; representation; embedding; latent variable; abstraction; transfer; representation dependence; inductive bias.

Week 9: Prediction, Explanation, and Interpretability

Guiding question: Is a highly accurate model epistemically successful if humans cannot understand why it predicts as it does?

Practice focus: Compare a simple interpretable model, a black-box predictor, and a post-hoc explanation; ask which explanatory demand each method actually satisfies.

Required readings:

- Leo Breiman, "Statistical Modeling: The Two Cultures."
- Zachary C. Lipton, "The Mythos of Model Interpretability."
- Cynthia Rudin, "Stop Explaining Black Box Machine Learning Models for High Stakes Decisions and Use Interpretable Models Instead," selections.

Key concepts: prediction; explanation; transparency; interpretability; post-hoc explanation; understanding; scientific versus engineering aims.

Week 10: Distribution Shift, Robustness, and Failure in Deployment

Guiding question: What happens to epistemic warrant when the deployment environment differs from the training distribution?

Practice focus: Evaluate accuracy and uncertainty under a toy distribution shift; identify which assumptions of the original evaluation have failed.

Required readings:

- Joaquin Quinonero-Candela et al., eds., Dataset Shift in Machine Learning, introductory selections.
- Yaniv Ovadia et al., "Can You Trust Your Model's Uncertainty? Evaluating Predictive Uncertainty under Dataset Shift," selections.
- Optional: Recht et al., "Do ImageNet Classifiers Generalize to ImageNet?" review selections.

Key concepts: covariate shift; concept shift; out-of-distribution prediction; robustness; calibration under shift; domain assumption; deployment.

Week 11: Foundation Models: Pretraining, Transfer, and General-Purpose Learning

Guiding question: What changes epistemically when one pretrained model is reused across many tasks, domains, and downstream users?

Practice focus: Map the pipeline from pretraining through prompting or fine-tuning to downstream evaluation; identify where evidence about one task does and does not transfer to another.

Required readings:

- Rishi Bommasani et al., "On the Opportunities and Risks of Foundation Models," selections.
- Goodfellow, Bengio, and Courville, Deep Learning, brief background selections on transfer and representation.
- Optional: instructor-provided technical note on pretraining, fine-tuning, and in-context learning.

Philosophy of Machine Learning

Key concepts: pretraining; transfer learning; fine-tuning; in-context learning; scale; downstream task; general-purpose model; evaluation transfer.

Week 12: Social Epistemology of Machine Learning

Guiding question: What happens when many people or institutions rely on the same models, datasets, and algorithmic recommendations?

Practice focus: Analyze a toy selection or prediction system in which an individually more accurate shared algorithm creates correlated choices or failures across decision makers.

Required readings:

- Jon Kleinberg and Manish Raghavan, "Algorithmic Monoculture and Social Welfare."
- Instructor-provided selections on correlated error, human-AI decision making, or algorithmic homogeneity.
- Optional: a short case study of common-model dependence in a deployed ML ecosystem.

Key concepts: algorithmic monoculture; correlated error; dependence; diversity; human-AI reliance; collective accuracy; social welfare.

Week 13: Synthesis: What Kind of Learning Does Machine Learning Achieve?

Guiding question: Does machine learning solve the problem of induction, give conditional answers to it, or merely make its assumptions explicit?

Practice focus: Compare four standards of epistemic success - test performance, PAC-style guarantee, calibrated uncertainty, and long-run convergence - and ask what each leaves out.

Required readings:

- Harman and Kulkarni, Reliable Reasoning, concluding selections.
- Oliver Schulte, "Formal Learning Theory," Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, selections, or Kevin T. Kelly, The Logic of Reliable Inquiry, introductory selections.
- No additional technical reading; students review the central ML papers from the semester.

Key concepts: learning; generalization; inductive bias; conditional guarantee; convergence; reliability; understanding; artificial inquiry.

AI and Society

Technology, Justice, and Social Progress

Instructor	Yao Fan
Level	Undergraduate Higher-Level
Prerequisites	1 introductory course in ethics; prior knowledge in data science is helpful but not assumed.
Format	Seminar-style discussion with short lectures, case analysis, structured debates, and applied writing assignments.

Course Description

Artificial intelligence systems increasingly classify persons, allocate opportunities, automate work, filter information, and shape public and private decision-making. This course asks how AI should be evaluated from the standpoint of philosophy, political economy, feminist and racial justice theory, and social epistemology. We begin with the COMPAS risk-assessment controversy and the philosophical literature on algorithmic bias, discrimination, and formal fairness. We then step back to study Rawlsian justice, libertarianism, socialism, feminist critique, and racial justice, asking how each framework changes our evaluation of AI systems. The final part of the course examines who benefits from AI-driven productivity gains, whether technological development can be directed, and how algorithmic monoculture may generate systematic exclusion and epistemic harms. The central question throughout is: when, if ever, does technological progress become social progress?

Central Questions

- What makes an algorithmic decision biased, discriminatory, arbitrary, fair, or just?
- Why can mathematically precise fairness criteria fail to capture substantive injustice?
- How do Rawlsian, libertarian, socialist, feminist, and racial justice perspectives change the evaluation of AI systems?
- How do private-sector incentives and governance arrangements shape the direction of AI development?
- Can technological change be redirected toward social welfare, worker power, democratic control, and epistemic pluralism?

Learning Objectives

By the end of the course, students will be able to:

- explain major philosophical debates about algorithmic bias, discrimination, formal fairness, and substantive fairness;
- compare Rawlsian, libertarian, socialist, feminist, and racial justice approaches to the distribution of benefits, burdens, opportunities, and power;
- analyze AI systems as sociotechnical systems shaped by markets, institutions, data practices, political choices, and social values;
- evaluate claims that AI increases productivity or welfare by asking who benefits, who is harmed, and what alternatives were possible;
- develop clear written arguments that integrate philosophical theory with concrete AI case studies; and
- communicate normative analysis to both academic and public audiences through papers, memos, and discussion.

Assignments and Evaluation

The assignments are designed to build from conceptual analysis to applied normative evaluation. Page counts may be adjusted depending on institutional calendar and course level.

Assignment	Weight	Purpose
Participation	15%	Active class participation, short in-class activities, and one brief discussion-opening responsibility.
short paper 1	25%	A short paper applying theories of justice to a concrete AI case.
Short paper 2	25%	A short paper on a more theoretical topic.
Final paper	35%	A longer paper.

Course Policies

Generative AI use: Because the course studies AI, we will discuss and occasionally experiment with AI tools. Unless an assignment specifies otherwise, students may use AI tools for brainstorming, outlining, clarifying concepts, and editing prose, but they must disclose such use in an AI-use note. Students may not submit uncited AI-generated prose, fabricated citations, or AI-produced analysis in place of their own argument. Students remain responsible for the accuracy, originality, and intellectual integrity of all submitted work.

Accessibility and inclusion: Students are encouraged to contact the instructor early about access needs, disability accommodations, religious observances, caregiving responsibilities, or other circumstances that may affect participation. The course is committed to respectful disagreement and to making difficult discussions intellectually serious and accessible.

Late work: Short extensions are available when requested in advance. Longer extensions or make-up arrangements should be discussed as soon as possible. The goal of the policy is to support learning while preserving fairness to the class.

Academic integrity: Students should cite all sources, distinguish their own claims from the claims of authors, and avoid misrepresenting evidence or arguments. Collaboration is welcome for discussion and study; submitted work must be the student's own unless a group assignment is explicitly designated.

Course Schedule

The schedule is organized in three movements: algorithmic fairness, theories of justice, and AI as directed technological change. Readings marked optional are recommended for students developing final projects in that area. More technical readings will be discussed conceptually; no programming background is required.

Part I. Algorithmic Bias, Fairness, and Governance

Week 1 - Introduction: AI as a Social Technology

Guiding question: *When does an apparently technical tool become a political decision-maker?*

Readings:

- Julia Angwin, Jeff Larson, Surya Mattu, and Lauren Kirchner, "Machine Bias," ProPublica (2016).
- Northpointe Inc., "COMPAS Risk Scales: Demonstrating Accuracy, Equity and Predictive Parity" (2016).

Week 2 - Algorithmic Bias and Discrimination

Guiding question: *What is "bias" in algorithmic decision-making, and how does it relate to implicit bias, classification, and social power?*

Readings:

- Gabrielle M. Johnson, "Algorithmic Bias: On the Implicit Biases of Social Technology," Synthese (2021).
- Duncan Purves and Jeremy Davis, "Should Algorithms that Predict Recidivism Have Access to Race?" American Philosophical Quarterly 60.2 (2023).

Optional:

- Linus Ta-Lun Huang, Hsiang-Yun Chen, Ying-Tung Lin, Tsung-Ren Huang, and Tzu-Wei Hung, "Ameliorating Algorithmic Bias, or Why Explainable AI Needs Feminist Philosophy," Feminist Philosophy Quarterly 8.3/4 (2022).

Week 3 - Formal Algorithmic Fairness**Guiding question:** *What do mathematical fairness criteria require, and why can they conflict?***Readings:**

- Sam Corbett-Davies, Johann D. Gaebler, Hamed Nilforoshan, Ravi Shroff, and Sharad Goel, "The Measure and Mismeasure of Fairness."
- Jon Kleinberg, Sendhil Mullainathan, and Manish Raghavan, "Inherent Trade-Offs in the Fair Determination of Risk Scores."

Week 4 - From Formal to Substantive Fairness**Guiding question:** *Why might a formally fair model still reproduce injustice?***Readings:**

- Ben Green, "Escaping the Impossibility of Fairness: From Formal to Substantive Algorithmic Fairness," *Philosophy & Technology* 35 (2022).
- Fabian Beigang, "On the Advantages of Distinguishing Between Predictive and Allocative Fairness in Algorithmic Decision-Making," *Minds and Machines* 32 (2022).

Optional:

- Matthias Kuppler, Christoph Kern, Ruben L. Bach, and Frauke Kreuter, "From Fair Predictions to Just Decisions?" *Frontiers in Sociology* 7 (2022).

Week 5 - Private-Sector AI, Incentives, and Governance**Guiding question:** *Can firms responsibly govern systems whose harms are tied to their business incentives?***Readings:**

- Tom Slee, "The Incompatible Incentives of Private-Sector AI."
- Thomas Ferretti, "An Institutional Approach to AI Ethics: Justifying the Priority of Government Regulation over Self-Regulation."

Optional:

- Brent Mittelstadt, "Principles Alone Cannot Guarantee Ethical AI," *Nature Machine Intelligence* (2019).

Part II. Theories of Justice**Week 6 - Rawls: Justice as Fairness and the Basic Structure****Guiding question:** *What would it mean for AI institutions to be justifiable to free and equal citizens?***Readings:**

- John Rawls, "Justice as Fairness."
- Leif Wenar, "John Rawls," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, selected sections.

Week 7 - Against Rawls I: Libertarianism and Entitlement**Guiding question:** *What, if anything, may the state demand from individuals or firms in the name of distributive justice?***Readings:**

- Robert Nozick, *Anarchy, State, and Utopia*, chapter 7, selections.

Week 8 - Against Rawls II: Socialism, Incentives, and Community**Guiding question:** *If technological gains require cooperation, how should their benefits be shared?***Readings:**

- G. A. Cohen, "Justice, Incentives and Selfishness."
- G. A. Cohen, *Why Not Socialism?*, chapters 1-2.

Week 9 - Feminist and Racial Justice Critiques**Guiding question:** *What does ideal theory miss when it abstracts away from family, care, race, segregation, and histories of domination?***Readings:**

- Susan Moller Okin, "'Forty Acres and a Mule' for Women: Rawls and Feminism."
- Elizabeth Anderson, *The Imperative of Integration*, chapter 1.

Optional:

- Charles W. Mills, "Rawls on Race/Race in Rawls" or "'Ideal Theory' as Ideology."

Part III. Technology, Power, and AI Futures

Week 10 - Who Benefits from Advances in AI?

Guiding question: *Does increased productivity automatically improve welfare, or can it intensify inequality and vulnerability?*

Readings:

- Mauro Cazzaniga, Augustus Panton, Longji Li, Carlo Pizzinelli, and Marina M. Tavares, "A Gender Lens on Labor Market Exposure to AI," AEA Papers and Proceedings 115 (2025).
- Shakked Noy and Whitney Zhang, "Experimental Evidence on the Productivity Effects of Generative Artificial Intelligence," Science 381.6654 (2023).

Week 11 - Directed Technological Change: Automation, Control, and Worker Power

Guiding question: *Can societies choose whether AI develops as labor replacement, worker augmentation, surveillance infrastructure, or public-good technology?*

Readings:

- Daron Acemoglu, David Autor, and Simon Johnson, "Can We Have Pro-Worker AI? Choosing a Path of Machines in Service of Minds" (2023).
- David F. Noble, "Social Choice in Machine Design: The Case of Automatically Controlled Machine Tools, and a Challenge for Labor."

Optional:

- Daron Acemoglu and Simon Johnson, Power and Progress, chapter 8, "The Contested Path."
- Acemoglu and Johnson, Power and Progress, chapter 12, "Redirecting Technology."

Week 12 - Algorithmic Monoculture I: Systematic Exclusion and Opportunity

Guiding question: *What happens when many institutions rely on the same or similar algorithmic screeners?*

Readings:

- Kathleen Creel and Deborah Hellman, "The Algorithmic Leviathan: Arbitrariness, Fairness, and Opportunity in Algorithmic Decision-Making Systems," Canadian Journal of Philosophy 52.1 (2022).

Optional:

- Brian Hedden and Manish Raghavan, "Algorithmic Monoculture and its Critics."

Week 13 - Algorithmic Monoculture II: Social Epistemology and Group Decision-Making

Guiding question: *Can shared AI systems make groups collectively less knowledgeable even when individuals receive better assistance?*

Readings:

- Fan, "Large Language Models, Algorithmic Monoculture, and Group Decision Making: An Epistemic Braess Paradox."

Optional:

- Kevin J. S. Zollman, "The Epistemic Benefit of Transient Diversity."

Yao Fan / SAMPLE SYLLABUS

Introduction to Ethics

The Good, the Right, and Why Morality Matters

LEVEL	FORMAT	LENGTH	PREREQUISITES
Introductory undergraduate	Lecture and discussion	13 weeks; two meetings weekly	None

Course Description

Ethics asks what makes a life go well, what we ought to do, and what reasons we have to care about morality. **This course introduces moral philosophy through the distinction between the good and the right.** We begin with trolley cases and reflective equilibrium to learn how philosophical arguments move among cases, principles, and theories. We then examine utilitarianism, deontology, and virtue ethics as rival ways of organizing moral thought: by maximizing value, respecting duties and persons, or cultivating character and flourishing.

The second half of the course steps back from the three theories to investigate competing accounts of goodness and well-being, accounts of right action and obligation, and the practical question **"Why be moral?"** These units also introduce selected metaethical questions about whether evaluative and deontic concepts are reducible and how moral reasons can be justified. Canonical texts are paired with accessible contemporary readings. No prior philosophy is assumed; the emphasis is on reconstructing arguments, applying concepts to cases, and revising views in response to objections.

COURSE DESIGN RATIONALE

The course is organized as an inquiry rather than a chronological survey. Week 1 equips students with a method; Weeks 2-7 introduce the three standard normative frameworks; Weeks 8-11 separate the evaluative and deontic concepts those frameworks presuppose; and Weeks 12-13 ask whether moral demands give agents reasons to act. Recurring cases make students' conceptual development visible across the semester.

Guiding Questions

- What makes lives, persons, experiences, or states of affairs good?
- What makes actions right, wrong, required, permissible, or beyond duty?
- Does rightness depend on promoting goodness, or can it constrain the pursuit of good?
- How should judgments, principles, and theories be revised when they conflict?
- What reason does an agent have to be moral?

Course Architecture

Weeks	Unit	Purpose in the course arc
1	Moral method	Begin with cases, argument reconstruction, and reflective equilibrium.
2-7	Normative theories	Compare utilitarianism, deontology, and virtue ethics as rival frameworks.
8-9	Theories of the good	Ask what is valuable, good for a person, or worth promoting.
10-11	Theories of the right	Analyze obligation, permission, rights, plural duties, and justifiability to others.
12-13	Why be moral?	Test whether morality gives agents reasons that are not reducible to self-interest.

Weekly rhythm: Meeting 1 emphasizes careful reconstruction of a central argument; Meeting 2 tests that argument through objections, cases, or comparative application. Assigned excerpts would be calibrated to the institution's class length and student population.

Course Schedule

The schedule assumes two 75-minute meetings each week. Readings are selected excerpts; exact page ranges and assignment dates would be supplied in the term calendar. Optional readings are marked as such.

WEEK 1 Moral Cases, Arguments, and Reflective Equilibrium	
CENTRAL QUESTION <i>How should we reason when our judgments about cases and our principles conflict?</i>	
MEETING 1 The Trolley Problem Focus: Switch, footbridge, and transplant cases; moral intuitions; identifying morally relevant features. Read: Instructor handout, "Good, Right, Ought, and Value"; Judith Jarvis Thomson, "The Trolley Problem" (excerpt). In class: Anonymous case poll followed by a feature map: intention, means, consent, proximity, and numbers.	MEETING 2 What Makes a Philosophical Argument? Focus: Premises and conclusions; counterexamples; considered judgments; narrow and wide reflective equilibrium. Read: John Rawls, A Theory of Justice, sec. 9 (excerpt); Norman Daniels, "Wide Reflective Equilibrium and Theory Acceptance in Ethics" (excerpt). In class: Reconstruct an argument, then build a first reflective-equilibrium map for a trolley case.
GOOD/RIGHT THREAD The course begins before choosing a theory: students learn to ask whether a verdict concerns value, obligation, character, or some combination. Milestone: Ungraded diagnostic argument map.	
WEEK 2 Utilitarianism I: The Right as Maximizing the Good	
CENTRAL QUESTION <i>Is the right action simply the one that produces the best overall outcome?</i>	
MEETING 1 Bentham and the Principle of Utility Focus: Consequentialism, hedonism, impartiality, aggregation, and the felicific calculus. Read: Jeremy Bentham, An Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation, chs. 1 and 4 (excerpts). In class: Apply Bentham's dimensions of value to a public-policy choice and test what the calculation leaves out.	MEETING 2 Mill on Happiness and Higher Pleasures Focus: Qualitative hedonism, competent judges, impartiality, and the relation between individual and general happiness. Read: John Stuart Mill, Utilitarianism, ch. 2. In class: Small groups reconstruct Mill's reply to the objection that utilitarianism is a doctrine worthy only of swine.
GOOD/RIGHT THREAD Utilitarianism makes the good explanatorily prior: right action is defined by the production of the best consequences. Milestone: Argument analysis entry 1.	
WEEK 3 Utilitarianism II: Justice, Integrity, and Demandingness	
CENTRAL QUESTION <i>Can maximizing the good require too much or permit actions that seem wrong?</i>	
MEETING 1 Justice and the Separateness of Persons Focus: Punishing the innocent, organ transplant cases, rights objections, and integrity. Read: John Stuart Mill, Utilitarianism, ch. 5 (selections); Bernard Williams, "A Critique of Utilitarianism" (excerpt). In class: Compare the trolley switch with a transplant case and identify whether aggregation treats persons separately enough.	MEETING 2 Demandingness and Utilitarian Replies Focus: Beneficence, partiality, personal projects, act and rule utilitarianism, and indirect strategies. Read: Peter Singer, "Famine, Affluence, and Morality" (excerpt); instructor guide to act and rule utilitarianism. In class: Construct the strongest demandingness objection and a utilitarian response to it.
GOOD/RIGHT THREAD The objections ask whether goodness can exhaust rightness, or whether justice, rights, and personal commitments introduce independent constraints. Milestone: Reflective-equilibrium case prompt distributed.	

INTRODUCTION TO ETHICS | YAO FAN - SAMPLE SYLLABUS

WEEK 4 | Deontology I: Duty and the Moral Law

CENTRAL QUESTION *Are some actions wrong regardless of the goodness of their consequences?*

MEETING 1 The Good Will and Acting from Duty

Focus: Good will, duty, inclination, moral worth, and unconditional value.**Read:** Immanuel Kant, Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals, sec. I.**In class:** Distinguish doing the right action from acting for the right reason through paired cases.

MEETING 2 The Formula of Universal Law

Focus: Maxims, universalization, contradictions in conception and will, and perfect and imperfect duties.**Read:** Kant, Groundwork, sec. II (Universal Law passages).**In class:** Formulate and test maxims for lying promises, refusing aid, and developing one's talents.**GOOD/RIGHT THREAD** Kant begins with the unconditional goodness of a good will but denies that right action is determined by maximizing good states of affairs. | **Milestone:** Argument analysis entry 2.

WEEK 5 | Deontology II: Respect, Rights, and Permissible Harm

CENTRAL QUESTION *What explains the difference between permissible and impermissible ways of bringing about harm?*

MEETING 1 Persons as Ends in Themselves

Focus: The Formula of Humanity, dignity, consent, coercion, and using a person merely as a means.**Read:** Kant, Groundwork, sec. II (Humanity passages); Onora O'Neill, "A Simplified Account of Kant's Ethics" (excerpt).**In class:** Evaluate cases of deception, coercion, and rescue using the distinction between using and merely using.

MEETING 2 Double Effect and Trolley Cases Revisited

Focus: Doing and allowing; intending and foreseeing; means and side effects; rights as constraints.**Read:** Philippa Foot, "The Problem of Abortion and the Doctrine of Double Effect" (excerpt); Thomson, "The Trolley Problem."**In class:** Create a case matrix and test which distinction best explains students' verdicts across variants.**GOOD/RIGHT THREAD** Deontology treats the right as constraining how good outcomes may be pursued, especially when persons would be used or wronged. | **Milestone:** Reflective equilibrium case analysis due.

WEEK 6 | Virtue Ethics I: Character, Flourishing, and the Human Good

CENTRAL QUESTION *Is ethics primarily about right action, or about becoming a good person and living well?*

MEETING 1 Eudaimonia and the Function Argument

Focus: The highest good, flourishing, the human function, and activity in accordance with virtue.**Read:** Aristotle, Nicomachean Ethics, Book I, chs. 1-7 (selections).**In class:** Distinguish a pleasant life, a successful life, and a flourishing life through counterexamples.

MEETING 2 Virtue, the Mean, and Habituation

Focus: Virtue as a state of character, the doctrine of the mean, emotion, practice, and moral education.**Read:** Aristotle, Nicomachean Ethics, Book II, chs. 1-6.**In class:** Analyze courage and generosity without treating the mean as a simple numerical midpoint.**GOOD/RIGHT THREAD** Virtue ethics begins from the good life and good character, then asks how right action is explained by excellent practical agency. | **Milestone:** Argument analysis entry 3.

WEEK 7 | Virtue Ethics II: Practical Wisdom and Action Guidance

CENTRAL QUESTION *Can practical wisdom guide action without reducing morality to a decision procedure?*

MEETING 1 Phronesis and Moral Perception

Focus: Practical wisdom, deliberation, particulars, emotion, and the unity of the virtues.**Read:** Aristotle, Nicomachean Ethics, Book VI, chs. 5 and 12-13 (selections).**In class:** Work through a context-sensitive case in which a simple rule and a wise response diverge.

MEETING 2 Does Virtue Ethics Tell Us What to Do?

Focus: The action-guidance objection, virtue rules, moral exemplars, and the worry about moral sainthood.**Read:** Rosalind Hursthouse, On Virtue Ethics, ch. 1 (excerpt); optional: Susan Wolf, "Moral Saints."**In class:** Compare how a utilitarian, a Kantian, and a virtuous agent would deliberate about the same promise.**GOOD/RIGHT THREAD** Virtue ethics may explain right action through what a virtuous person would characteristically do, but it also challenges action-first models of ethics. | **Milestone:** Comparative essay workshop.

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WEEK 8 | Theories of the Good I: Value and Hedonism**CENTRAL QUESTION** *What do we mean when we say that something is good, valuable, or good for someone?***MEETING 1 Kinds of Value and the Open Question****Focus:** Intrinsic and instrumental value; final value; good-for and good simpliciter; naturalism and non-naturalism.**Read:** G. E. Moore, *Principia Ethica* (selections on the open-question argument and intrinsic value); instructor value-concepts guide.**In class:** Classify examples of money, friendship, knowledge, pleasure, and virtue across different kinds of value.**MEETING 2 Hedonism and the Experience Machine****Focus:** Pleasure as the sole constituent of well-being; experience versus reality; authenticity and achievement.**Read:** Robert Nozick, "The Experience Machine"; review Mill, *Utilitarianism*, ch. 2.**In class:** Design one modification of the machine that isolates what students think is missing from pleasure alone.**GOOD/RIGHT THREAD** Theories that tell us to promote the good remain incomplete until we know what the good consists in and whether it is agent-neutral or good-for someone. | **Milestone:** Comparative normative theory essay due.**WEEK 9 | Theories of the Good II: Desire and Objective Goods****CENTRAL QUESTION** *Is something good for us because we desire it, or should we desire it because it is good?***MEETING 1 Desire-Satisfaction Theories****Focus:** Actual and informed desires, preference satisfaction, mistaken desires, and adaptive preferences.**Read:** Derek Parfit, *Reasons and Persons*, Appendix I, "What Makes Someone's Life Go Best?" (desire-based sections).**In class:** Test desire theories against cases of misinformation, manipulation, and desires that concern other people.**MEETING 2 Objective Lists and Perfectionism****Focus:** Knowledge, friendship, achievement, autonomy, virtue, and plural goods; worries about elitism and paternalism.**Read:** Parfit, "What Makes Someone's Life Go Best?" (objective-list section); review Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, Book I.**In class:** Build and defend a provisional theory of well-being, then expose it to a class-generated counterexample.**GOOD/RIGHT THREAD** The unit separates theories of what is valuable from theories of what we are required to do with value. | **Milestone:** Argument analysis entry 4.**WEEK 10 | Theories of the Right I: Obligation, Permission, and Plural Duties****CENTRAL QUESTION** *What is the difference between what is good to do, what is permissible, and what is required?***MEETING 1 The Deontic Landscape****Focus:** Right, wrong, obligatory, permissible, forbidden, supererogatory, excuse, and justification.**Read:** Instructor handout, "Obligation, Permission, and Supererogation"; J. O. Urmson, "Saints and Heroes" (excerpt).**In class:** Place cases of rescue, charity, forgiveness, and sacrifice on a deontic map and defend the boundaries.**MEETING 2 Ross and Prima Facie Duties****Focus:** Fidelity, reparation, gratitude, justice, beneficence, non-maleficence, and conflicts among duties.**Read:** W. D. Ross, *The Right and the Good*, ch. 2 (selections).**In class:** Deliberate about a promise that conflicts with preventing harm, then distinguish prima facie from actual duty.**GOOD/RIGHT THREAD** Ross rejects the reduction of rightness to value: promoting good is one duty among several, not the master principle of morality. | **Milestone:** Good/right thesis clinic.**WEEK 11 | Theories of the Right II: Contractualism, Rights, and Reasons****CENTRAL QUESTION** *Is an action wrong when it cannot be justified to each person affected by it?***MEETING 1 What We Owe to Each Other****Focus:** Reasonable rejection, interpersonal justification, complaints, and the contrast with aggregation.**Read:** T. M. Scanlon, *What We Owe to Each Other*, Introduction and ch. 5 (excerpts).**In class:** Compare utilitarian and contractualist treatment of a case involving many small benefits and one severe burden.**MEETING 2 Rights and Agent-Relative Reasons****Focus:** Rights and correlative duties; agent-neutral and agent-relative reasons; promoting versus respecting value.**Read:** Thomas Nagel, short selection on agent-relative and agent-neutral reasons; instructor guide on rights.**In class:** Analyze whether a right supplies a reason to produce fewer violations or a reason not to violate it oneself.**GOOD/RIGHT THREAD** Contractualism and rights-based views explain the right through relations among persons, not solely through the value of outcomes. | **Milestone:** The good and the right essay due.

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WEEK 12 Why Be Moral? I: Egoism and the Amoralist Challenge	
CENTRAL QUESTION <i>If injustice benefits me and I can avoid punishment, what reason do I have to act morally?</i>	
MEETING 1 The Ring of Gyges Focus: Justice and self-interest; psychological and ethical egoism; reputation versus genuine moral motivation. Read: Plato, Republic, Book II, 357a-367e (Gyges and Glaucon's challenge). In class: State the strongest version of the amoralist challenge without presupposing that morality already matters.	MEETING 2 Contractarian Answers Focus: The state of nature, rational cooperation, assurance, enforcement, and morality as mutually advantageous constraint. Read: Thomas Hobbes, Leviathan, chs. 13-15 (excerpts). In class: Use a repeated prisoner's dilemma to test whether self-interest can explain moral compliance and its limits.
GOOD/RIGHT THREAD The question shifts from what is good or right to whether either supplies an agent with a reason to act. Milestone: Argument analysis entry 5; final paper proposal.	

WEEK 13 Why Be Moral? II: Reasons, Normativity, and Course Synthesis	
CENTRAL QUESTION <i>Can morality give us reasons independently of what we already desire or value?</i>	
MEETING 1 Internal and External Reasons Focus: Desire-based reasons, hypothetical imperatives, categorical demands, identity, and rational self-constitution. Read: Philippa Foot, "Morality as a System of Hypothetical Imperatives" (excerpt); Bernard Williams, "Internal and External Reasons" (excerpt); optional: Christine Korsgaard, The Sources of Normativity (excerpt). In class: Stage a structured dialogue between an amoralist and two competing accounts of moral reasons.	MEETING 2 Reflective Equilibrium Revisited Focus: Course review; theory choice; moral pluralism; methodological limits; returning to the opening cases. Read: No new reading. Revisit the Week 1 diagnostic, selected passages from Mill, Kant, Aristotle, Ross, and Scanlon. In class: Re-vote on the opening cases, compare the reasons now offered, and draft the final paper's governing objection and reply.
GOOD/RIGHT THREAD The course closes by asking whether our final view integrates a defensible account of value, obligation, character, and moral reasons. Milestone: Final position paper due in the exam period.	

PART 3

Teaching Evaluation

Student letter, evaluation summary, reviews, and reports.

June 25th, 2026

To whom it may concern,

I am very pleased to recommend Dr. Yao Fan for a teaching position at your institution. Dr. Fan was our teaching assistant for the History of Modern Philosophy course (PHIL 0210) at the University of Pittsburgh during the Spring 2021 term. Although this course met solely online, due to the Covid-19 pandemic, Dr. Fan still managed to make this undergraduate course feel like a normal in-person course by holding engaging recitations. I am very confident that Dr. Fan would be an excellent teacher within your institution, as he played a crucial part in helping me understand the complex lecture material and readings.

This course was my very first introduction to philosophy and I was grateful and relieved to have Dr. Fan guide us through the professor's lectures. During his recitations, he asked thought-provoking open-ended questions to the class. He gave students the opportunity to voice their thoughts and would prompt further discussion by asking students to elaborate further in a reassuring manner. His discussion-focused recitations kept the course material interesting, which motivated me to persevere through the more difficult philosophy readings.

I also found Dr. Fan's office hours extremely valuable because he would simplify challenging course material by offering alternative explanations, analogies, and diagrams. He always demonstrated patience and made me feel comfortable to say, "I still don't understand". I also greatly appreciated Dr. Fan's thorough feedback on papers and willingness to schedule more office hours if students were still confused.

In closing, I highly recommend Dr. Yao Fan and know he will make a positive impact on his students' academic pursuits just as he did mine. Should you have any further questions, please do not hesitate to contact me at 267-885-9407 or at giuliaapascucci@gmail.com.

Sincerely,

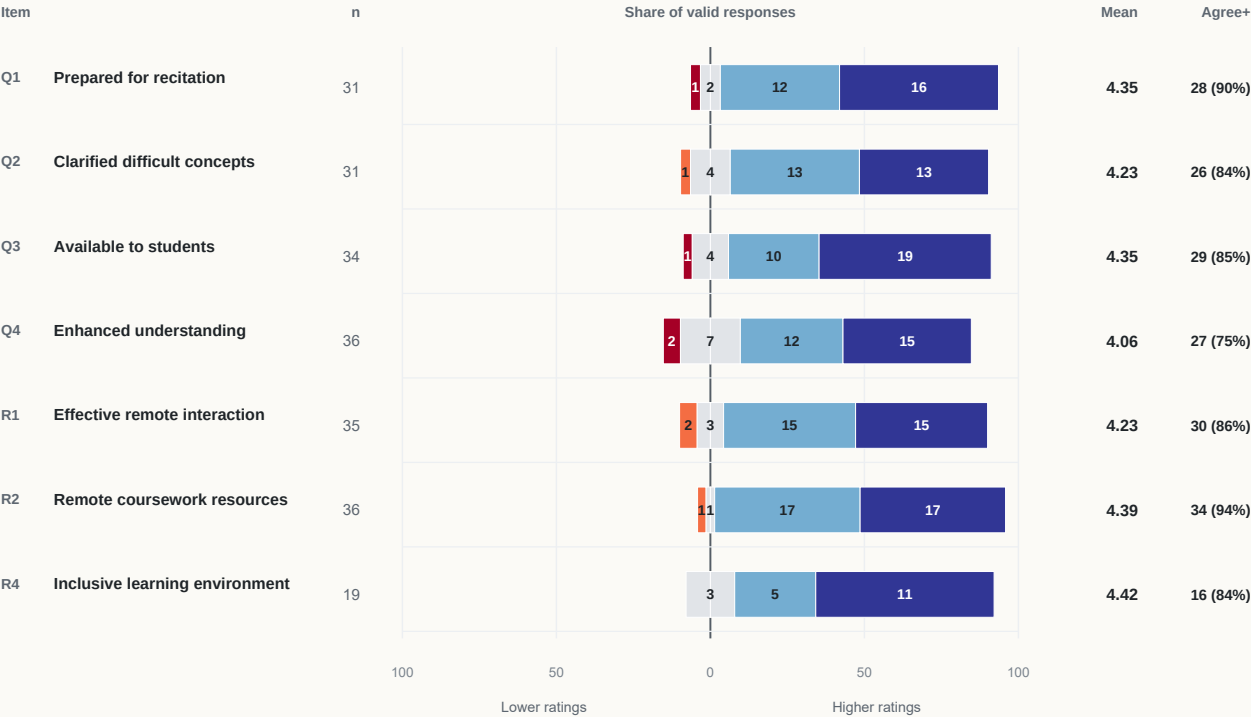

Giulia M. Pascucci

Teaching Evaluation Response Distribution

Likert-style stacked bars by survey item. Bar labels show raw counts; widths show shares of valid responses.

Missing responses are excluded separately for each item.
Response

1 Strongly Disagree 2 Disagree 3 Neutral 4 Agree 5 Strongly Agree



Note: numbers inside bars are response counts; #N/A responses are excluded separately for each item.

Fine print

Source: anonymous teaching evaluations from six recitation sections taught as Teaching Assistant at the University of Pittsburgh, remotely in Fall 2020 and Spring 2021.

Courses: Concepts of Human Nature (2020), three sections of approximately 20 students each, covering Plato, Hobbes, Rousseau, Marx, and Freud; Introduction to History of Modern Philosophy (2021), three sections of approximately 20 students each, covering Descartes, Locke, Hume, and Kant.

Question wording:

- Q1 The recitation instructor was prepared for recitation;
- Q2 The recitation instructor used appropriate examples to clarify difficult concepts;
- Q3 The recitation instructor was available to me in person, electronically, or both;
- Q4 The recitation enhanced my understanding of the class material;
- R1 I was able to interact effective with the instructor during the remote aspect of this course;
- R2 I had the resources I needed to finish my coursework during the remote aspect of this course;
- R4 The instructor creates an inclusive learning environment for all students.

R4, inclusive learning environment, was asked only for Introduction to History of Modern Philosophy.

One question in the survey ("The remote aspect of this course made it difficult/easy for me to learn") is omitted from the summary because it is less directly about the instructor's teaching ability.

One plagiarism case occurred in section 1905 of Concepts of Human Nature; the student was reported to the university and failed the course. Several lower-end responses (one for each question) came from that section. These two facts could be related.

The complete raw teaching evaluation reports follow the selected student reviews.

Selected Reviews

Anonymous teaching evaluation comments

- I liked that he took the time to explain difficult topics and thoroughly went over the content leaving nothing out of his explanation. It really helped me understand the content more and enhance my thinking about the topic at hand.
- He knows what he is talking about and is very nice.
- He was extremely informed and showed that he cared a lot about his students and their discussions.
- Yao is amazing and he really was able to deepen my understanding of the content.
- It was very engaging, and Yao's a great guy.
- He was really understanding.
- Yao Fan helped clarify what we learned in lectures. His explanations really helped my understanding of the different texts and philosophers.
- I really liked how he was able to simplify the difficult concepts from the reading and give many examples. Always willing to answer questions!
- Yao always seemed happy to talk to the students and he really enjoyed the subject.
- Yao was very open to questions and gave the best answers he could give!
- Successful in clarifying the dense content of lectures and optimizing instruction towards assignments.
- When we are put into groups, Yao would enter our group around three times in a recitation so whenever we were confused on an issue, we could ask him. I think this was very good because it helped me understand a lot more about the material.
- The recitation provided a lot of clarity to the lectures especially since the lectures were very text-heavy and moved very quickly.



Fall 2020 - Yao Fan PHIL 0010 - CONCEPTS OF HUMAN NATURE - 1220 - Recitation

Project Title: 2211 - Teaching Survey Fall 2020

Courses Audience: 20
Responses Received: 6
Response Rate: 30.0%

Subject Details	
Name	PHIL 0010 - CONCEPTS OF HUMAN NATURE - 1220 - Recitation
DEPARTMENT_CD	PHIL
CAMPUS_CD	PIT
SCHOOL_CD	ARTSC
CLASS_NBR	22827
SECTION_NUMBER	1220
TERM_NUMBER	2211
COURSE_TYPE	Recitation
CLASS_ATTRIBUTE	
First Name	Yao
Last Name	Fan
RANK_DESCR	Teaching Assistant
TENURE	NT

Report Comments

Included in this report:

- Responses to numerical questions
- Responses to instructor added questions (if applicable)
- Student comments
- Questions about remote teaching and learning

Interpreting OMET Teaching Survey Reports

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- In the future, discuss, teach, and model giving meaningful feedback with your students. Give them multiple opportunities to practice giving feedback. We have several resources that can help guide the discussion and options for gathering student feedback throughout the term.

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Creation Date: Friday, December 25, 2020

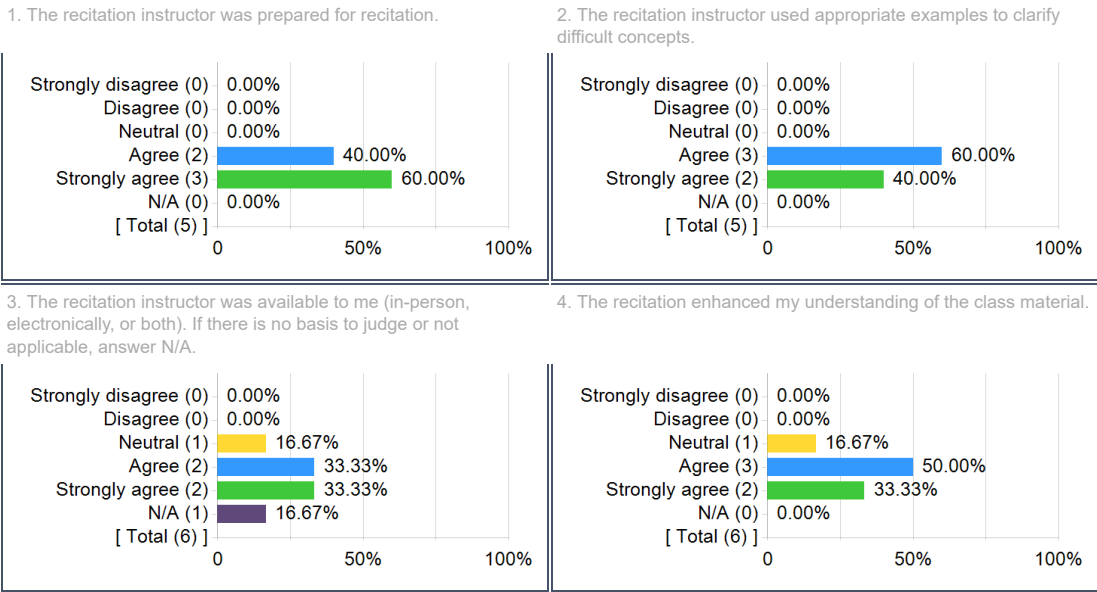
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ARTSC Recitation Questions

Summary: 5-point scale - Strongly Disagree to Strongly Agree

Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
The recitation instructor was prepared for recitation.	5	4.60	0.55
The recitation instructor used appropriate examples to clarify difficult concepts.	5	4.40	0.55
The recitation instructor was available to me (in-person, electronically, or both). If there is no basis to judge or not applicable, answer N/A.	5	4.20	0.84
The recitation enhanced my understanding of the class material.	6	4.17	0.75

Detailed Responses



Comments

What did you like best about the recitation instruction?

Comments
The guided worksheets to keep us on track.
It was very engaging, and Yao's a great guy.
Yao was extremely nice, approachable, and very informative. His worksheets were very helpful in allowing me to further understand class topics.
He was really understanding.
I liked the recitation worksheets, they really helped me understand the material from lecture much better

If you were running this recitation, what would you do differently?

Comments
More group discussion.
Maybe a different style of recitation worksheets, if I had to add any constructive criticism at all. Yao was a great instructor, and he was very flexible.
N/A
grade less harshly, I feel like grading was extremely harsh for an introductory philosophy course that most are taking for gen ed credit.
nothing

Remote Instruction and Learning Questions

As part of the University's response to the COVID-19 pandemic, many courses continued to hold remote class meetings during all or part of the fall term. Students were asked to provide feedback about the remote aspect of the course.

Instructor Interaction

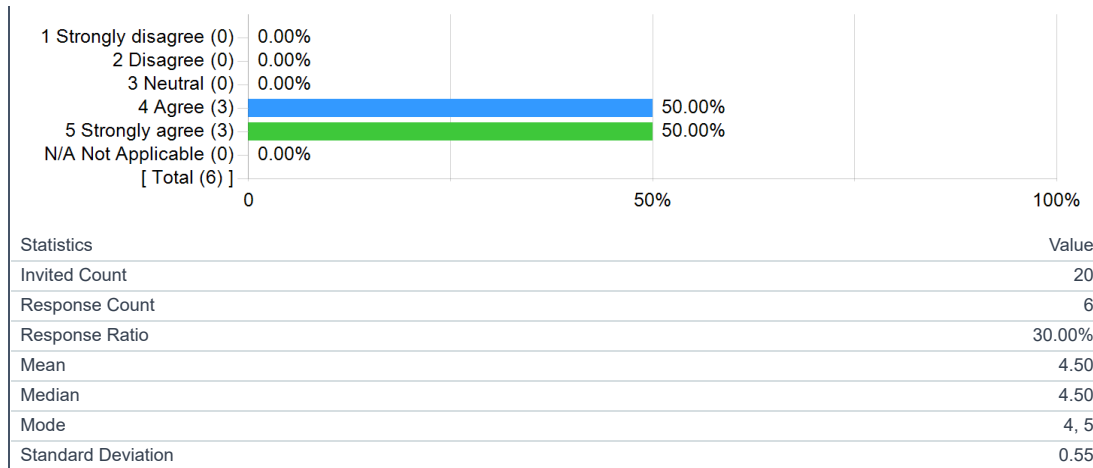
Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
I was able to interact effectively with the instructor during the remote aspect of this course.	6	4.50	0.55

Course Resources

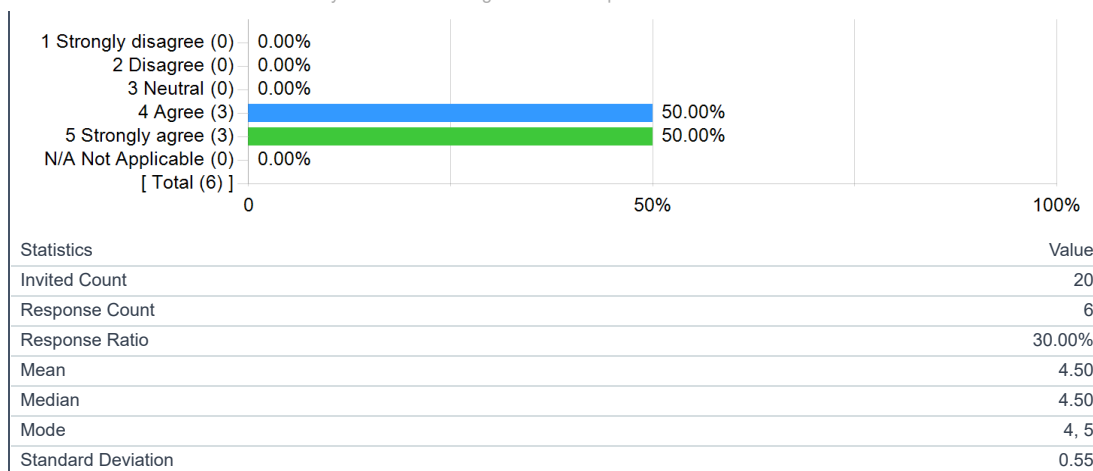
Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
I had the resources I needed to finish my coursework during the remote aspect of this course.	6	4.50	0.55

Instructor and Course Details

I was able to interact effectively with the instructor during the remote aspect of this course.

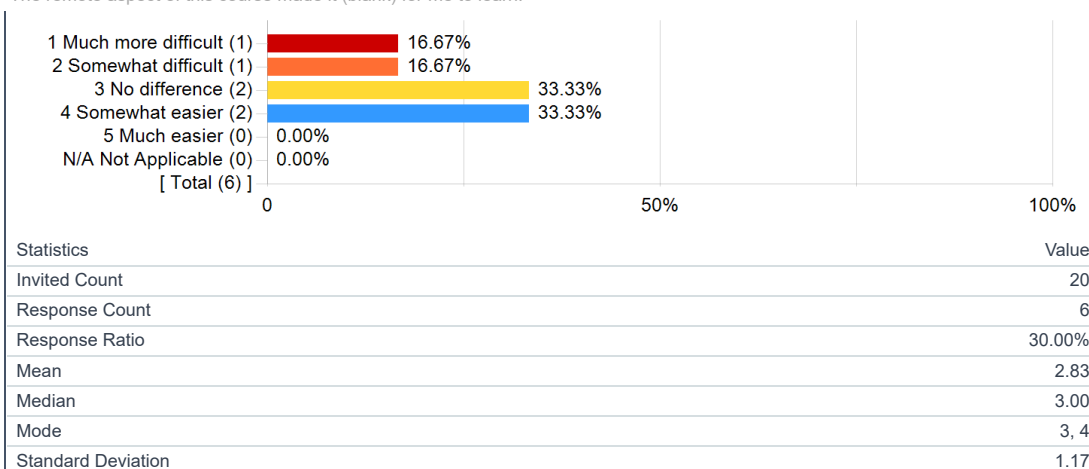


I had the resources I needed to finish my coursework during the remote aspect of this course.



Level of Difficulty

The remote aspect of this course made it (blank) for me to learn.



What do you think the University should know about your experience as a student in the current remote learning situation?

Students
I am fine as of now.
I think they need to know that it's a rough time compared to in-person. Becoming engaged in material is much harder than it is in person. However, with this comes more flexibility; but watching all of your classes from your desk is very depressing. Despite this, there is still no need to rush to in-person learning, as pandemic cases are reaching a National all-time high.
I am home this semester and am even more disconnected than other students living on campus.
I dislike online learning, I do much better in in-person classes
It is hard to adjust to learning online and the school has set many expectations too high when we are all still trying to figure out this lifestyle



Fall 2020 - Yao Fan PHIL 0010 - CONCEPTS OF HUMAN NATURE - 1901 - Recitation

Project Title: 2211 - Teaching Survey Fall 2020

Courses Audience: 20

Responses Received: 8

Response Rate: 40.0%

Subject Details	
Name	PHIL 0010 - CONCEPTS OF HUMAN NATURE - 1901 - Recitation
DEPARTMENT_CD	PHIL
CAMPUS_CD	PIT
SCHOOL_CD	ARTSC
CLASS_NBR	26893
SECTION_NUMBER	1901
TERM_NUMBER	2211
COURSE_TYPE	Recitation
CLASS_ATTRIBUTE	
First Name	Yao
Last Name	Fan
RANK_DESCR	Teaching Assistant
TENURE	NT

Report Comments

Included in this report:

- Responses to numerical questions
- Responses to instructor added questions (if applicable)
- Student comments
- Questions about remote teaching and learning

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Creation Date: Friday, December 25, 2020

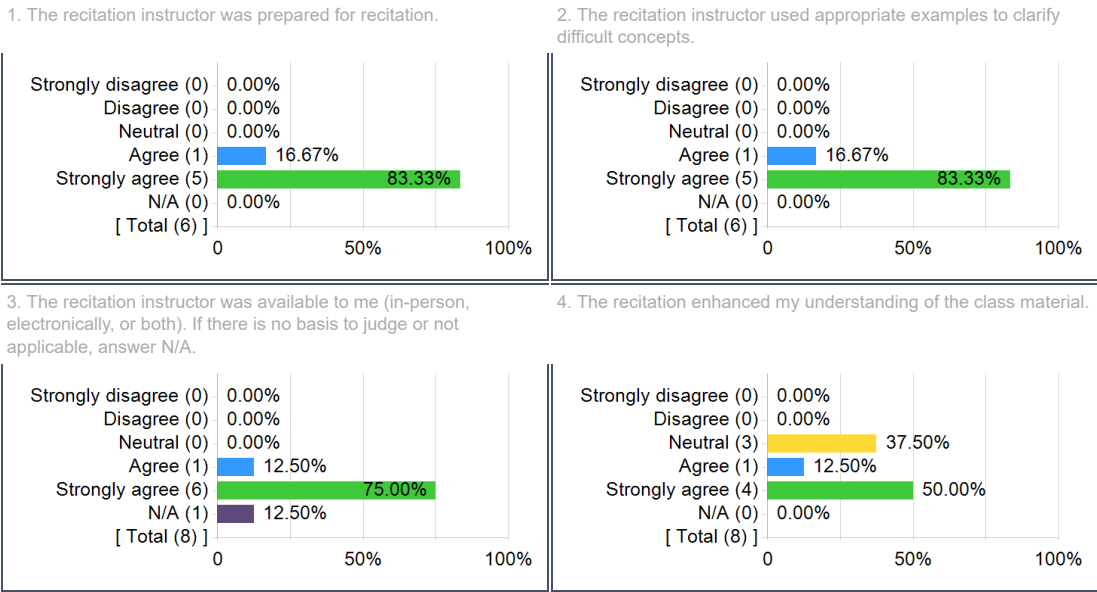
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ARTSC Recitation Questions

Summary: 5-point scale - Strongly Disagree to Strongly Agree

Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
The recitation instructor was prepared for recitation.	6	4.83	0.41
The recitation instructor used appropriate examples to clarify difficult concepts.	6	4.83	0.41
The recitation instructor was available to me (in-person, electronically, or both). If there is no basis to judge or not applicable, answer N/A.	7	4.86	0.38
The recitation enhanced my understanding of the class material.	8	4.13	0.99

Detailed Responses



Comments

What did you like best about the recitation instruction?

Comments
He knows what he is talking about and is very nice
I liked how he supplied worksheets and other guides to the various topics we discussed.
He was extremely informed and showed that he cared a lot about his students and their discussions
Yao is amazing and he really was able to deepen my understanding of the content
I like the additional lecture because it was helpful in understanding the readings

If you were running this recitation, what would you do differently?

Comments
I would not have breakout rooms with only two people since it made it really awkward to work with one another.
I would not put students into groups and have them discuss the topic on their own. We already do that outside of class time so I see no reason as to why we need to do it in class.
Have some further incentive to show up the recitation meeting besides simply participating in discussions.
nothing
I would utilize the discussion board instead of group discussions.

Remote Instruction and Learning Questions

As part of the University's response to the COVID-19 pandemic, many courses continued to hold remote class meetings during all or part of the fall term. Students were asked to provide feedback about the remote aspect of the course.

Instructor Interaction

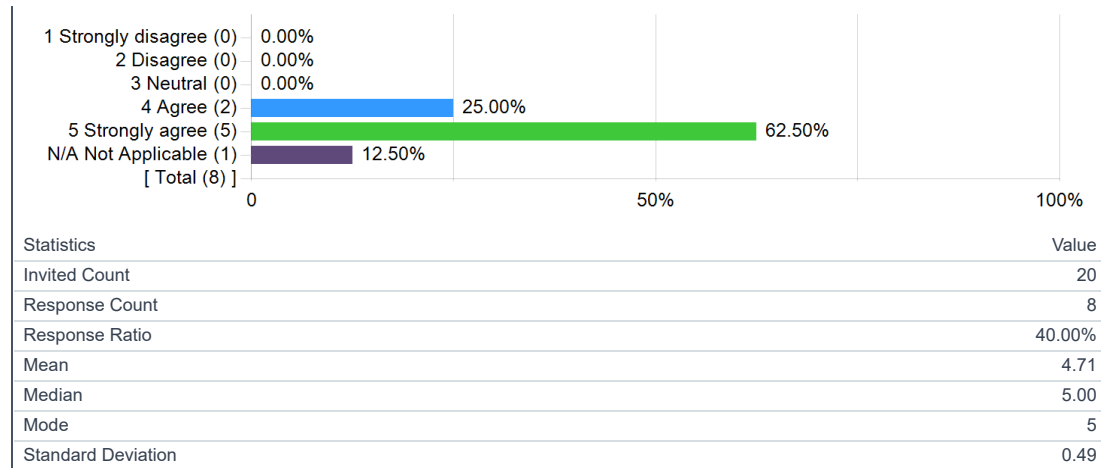
Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
I was able to interact effectively with the instructor during the remote aspect of this course.	7	4.71	0.49

Course Resources

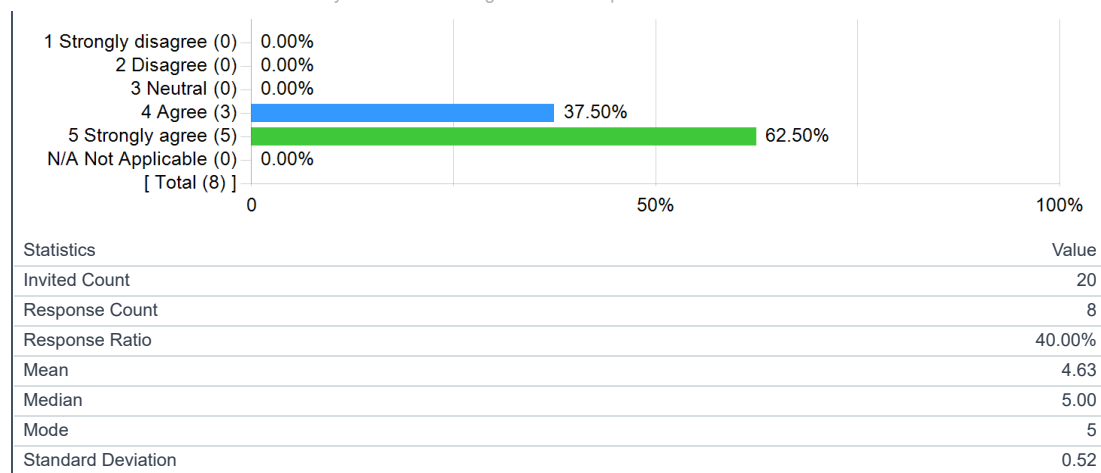
Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
I had the resources I needed to finish my coursework during the remote aspect of this course.	8	4.63	0.52

Instructor and Course Details

I was able to interact effectively with the instructor during the remote aspect of this course.

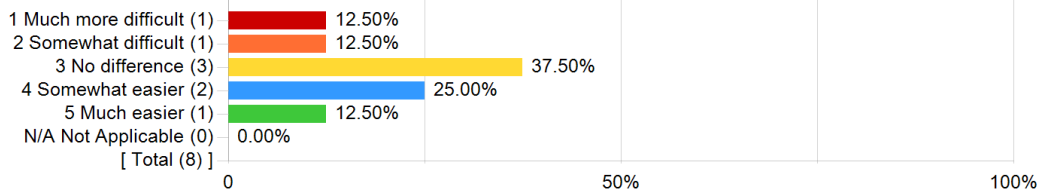


I had the resources I needed to finish my coursework during the remote aspect of this course.



Level of Difficulty

The remote aspect of this course made it (blank) for me to learn.



Statistics	Value
Invited Count	20
Response Count	8
Response Ratio	40.00%
Mean	3.13
Median	3.00
Mode	3
Standard Deviation	1.25

What do you think the University should know about your experience as a student in the current remote learning situation?

Students
The grading system should be altered for every class to accommodate the difficulties of remote learning
Online learning should be offered for all courses all the time.



Fall 2020 - Yao Fan PHIL 0010 - CONCEPTS OF HUMAN NATURE - 1905 - Recitation

Project Title: 2211 - Teaching Survey Fall 2020

Courses Audience: 19

Responses Received: 3

Response Rate: 15.79%

Subject Details	
Name	PHIL 0010 - CONCEPTS OF HUMAN NATURE - 1905 - Recitation
DEPARTMENT_CD	PHIL
CAMPUS_CD	PIT
SCHOOL_CD	ARTSC
CLASS_NBR	26433
SECTION_NUMBER	1905
TERM_NUMBER	2211
COURSE_TYPE	Recitation
CLASS_ATTRIBUTE	
First Name	Yao
Last Name	Fan
RANK_DESCR	Teaching Assistant
TENURE	NT

Report Comments

Included in this report:

- Responses to numerical questions
- Responses to instructor added questions (if applicable)
- Student comments
- Questions about remote teaching and learning

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Creation Date: Friday, December 25, 2020

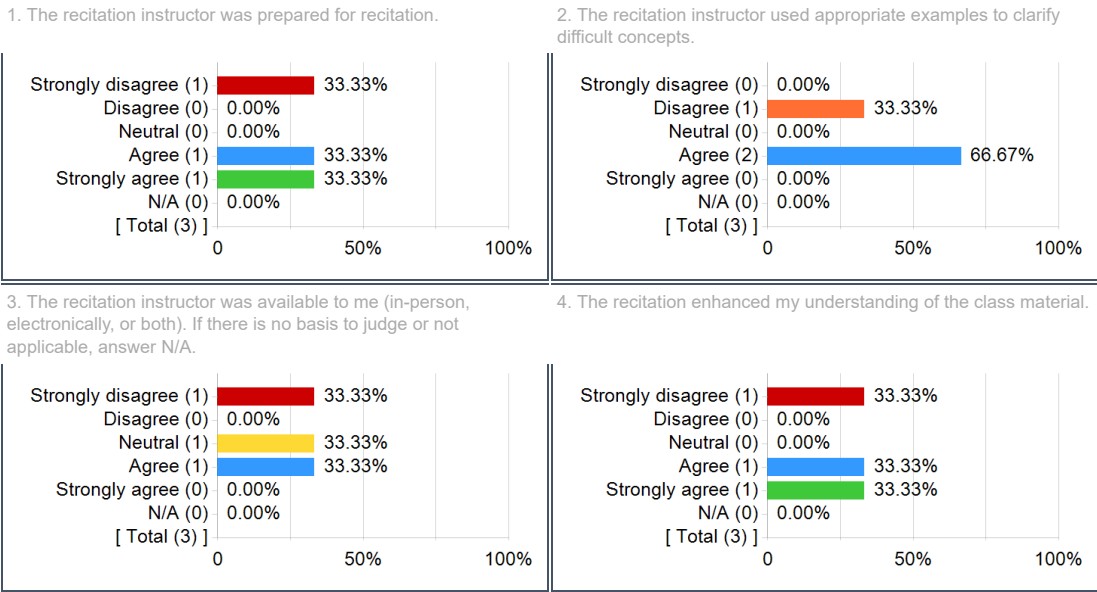
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ARTSC Recitation Questions

Summary: 5-point scale - Strongly Disagree to Strongly Agree

Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
The recitation instructor was prepared for recitation.	3	3.33	2.08
The recitation instructor used appropriate examples to clarify difficult concepts.	3	3.33	1.15
The recitation instructor was available to me (in-person, electronically, or both). If there is no basis to judge or not applicable, answer N/A.	3	2.67	1.53
The recitation enhanced my understanding of the class material.	3	3.33	2.08

Detailed Responses



Comments

What did you like best about the recitation instruction?

Comments

I liked that he took the time to explain difficult topics and thoroughly went over the content leaving nothing out of his explanation. It really helped me understand the content more and enhance my thinking about the topic at hand.

I liked when you answered specific questions we had

If you were running this recitation, what would you do differently?

Comments

One thing that I would do differently would be to make larger discussion groups instead of having just two people per group and shortening the amount of time given to discuss so that there is more time for questions and explanation from the TA.

I would answer the questions as a group, not in individual breakout rooms

Remote Instruction and Learning Questions

As part of the University's response to the COVID-19 pandemic, many courses continued to hold remote class meetings during all or part of the fall term. Students were asked to provide feedback about the remote aspect of the course.

Instructor Interaction

Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
I was able to interact effectively with the instructor during the remote aspect of this course.	3	3.33	1.15

Course Resources

Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
I had the resources I needed to finish my coursework during the remote aspect of this course.	3	4.33	0.58

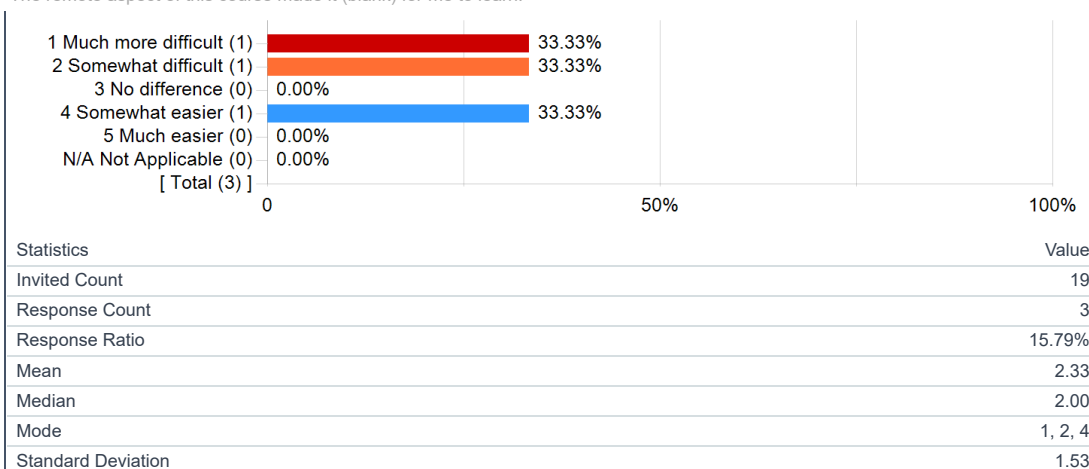
Instructor and Course Details

I was able to interact effectively with the instructor during the remote aspect of this course.	
1 Strongly disagree (0)	0.00%
2 Disagree (1)	33.33%
3 Neutral (0)	0.00%
4 Agree (2)	66.67%
5 Strongly agree (0)	0.00%
N/A Not Applicable (0)	0.00%
[Total (3)]	
Statistics	Value
Invited Count	19
Response Count	3
Response Ratio	15.79%
Mean	3.33
Median	4.00
Mode	4
Standard Deviation	1.15

I had the resources I needed to finish my coursework during the remote aspect of this course.	
1 Strongly disagree (0)	0.00%
2 Disagree (0)	0.00%
3 Neutral (0)	0.00%
4 Agree (2)	66.67%
5 Strongly agree (1)	33.33%
N/A Not Applicable (0)	0.00%
[Total (3)]	
Statistics	Value
Invited Count	19
Response Count	3
Response Ratio	15.79%
Mean	4.33
Median	4.00
Mode	4
Standard Deviation	0.58

Level of Difficulty

The remote aspect of this course made it (blank) for me to learn.



What do you think the University should know about your experience as a student in the current remote learning situation?

Students

The motivation aspect of doing work takes a much greater toll on students than anything else that is harder. The number of long-term/amount of busy work given during this time is overwhelming because it is much harder to have a connection with the professor or TAs since everything is online. Things that could be answered in a 10 second question at the end of class or after a class in person makes such a difference that I as a student took for granted.

It was ok.



Spring 2021 - Yao Fan PHIL 0210 - HISTORY OF MODERN PHILOSOPHY - 1070 - Recitation

Project Title: 2214 - Teaching Survey Spring 2021

Courses Audience: 17
Responses Received: 5
Response Rate: 29.41%

Report Comments

Included in this report:

- Responses to numerical questions
- Responses to instructor added questions (if applicable)
- Student comments

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Creation Date: Wednesday, May 19, 2021

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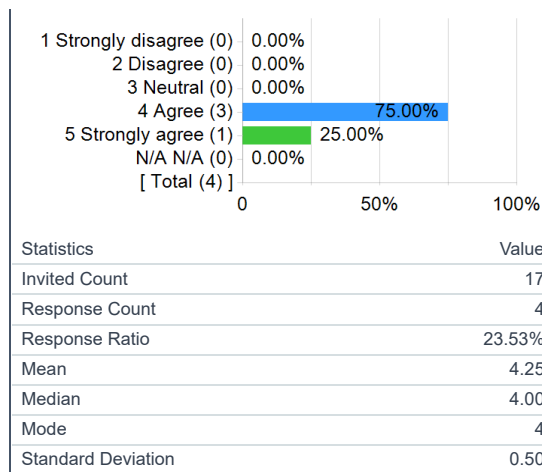
Recitation Questions

Summary: 5-point scale - Strongly Disagree to Strongly Agree

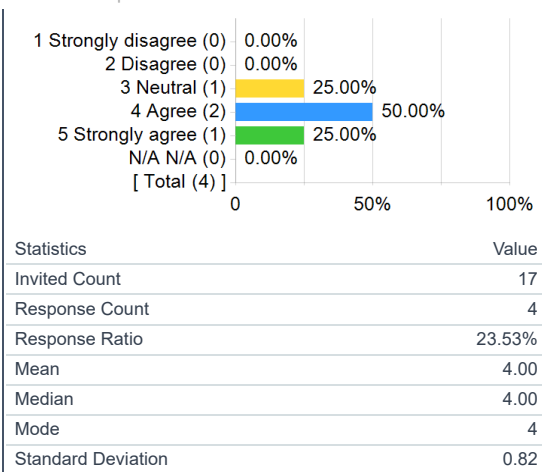
Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
The recitation instructor was prepared for recitation.	4	4.25	0.50
The recitation instructor used appropriate examples to clarify difficult concepts.	4	4.00	0.82
The recitation instructor was available to me (in-person, electronically, or both). If there is no basis to judge or not applicable, answer N/A.	5	4.80	0.45
The recitation enhanced my understanding of the class material.	5	4.20	0.84

Detailed Responses

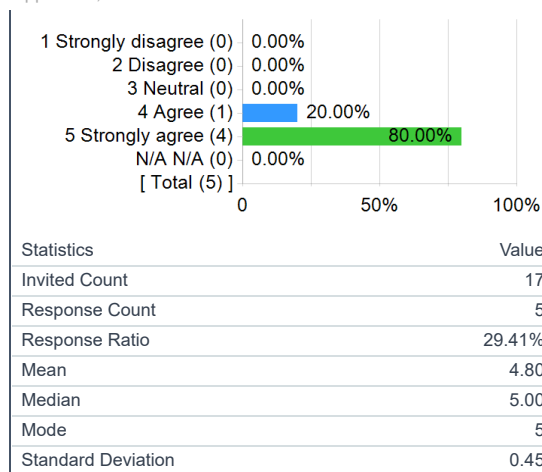
1. The recitation instructor was prepared for recitation.



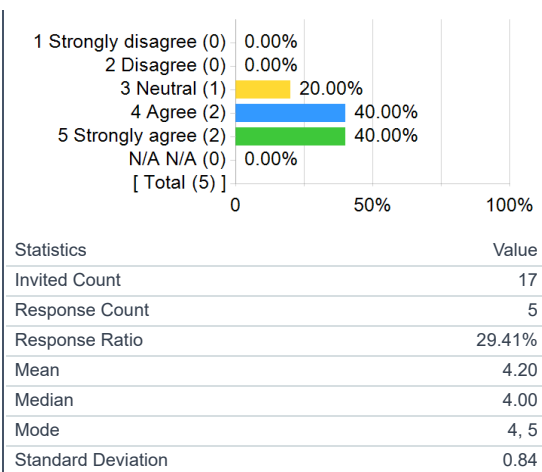
2. The recitation instructor used appropriate examples to clarify difficult concepts.



3. The recitation instructor was available to me (in-person, electronically, or both). If there is no basis to judge or not applicable, answer N/A.



4. The recitation enhanced my understanding of the class material.



Comments

What did you like best about the recitation instruction?

Comments
The students were able to talk to each other about the readings which was sometimes helpful.
Discussion based
HE was there
Yao Fan helped clarify what we learned in lectures. His explanations really helped my understanding of the different texts and philosophers.

If you were running this recitation, what would you do differently?

Comments
I would spend less time having students talking to each other and more time explaining in more detail certain important points in the reading.
Explain essay topics more in depth
Be more entertaining
I would make the break out rooms shorter. Have more time for discussion with the whole class together at the end.

Remote Instruction and Learning Questions

Instructor Interaction

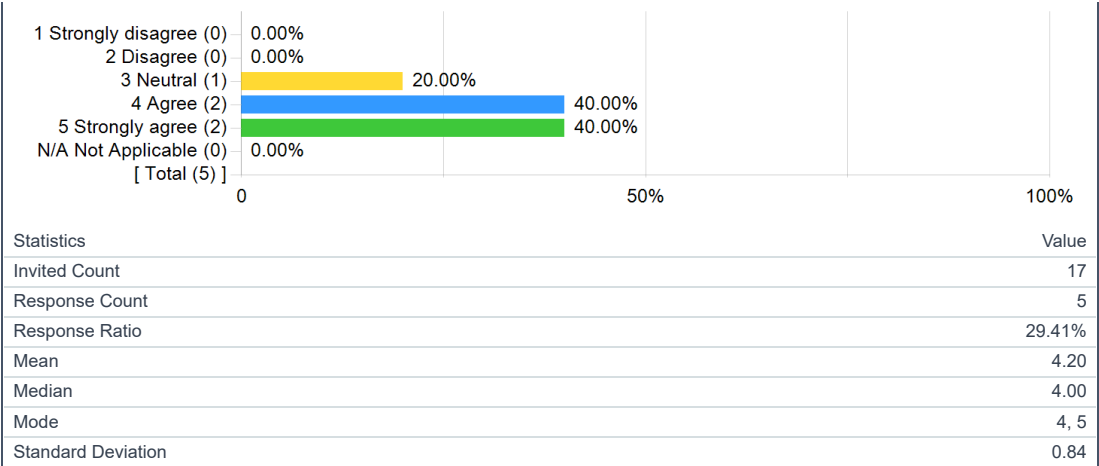
Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
I was able to interact effectively with the instructor during the remote aspect of this course.	5	4.20	0.84

Course Resources

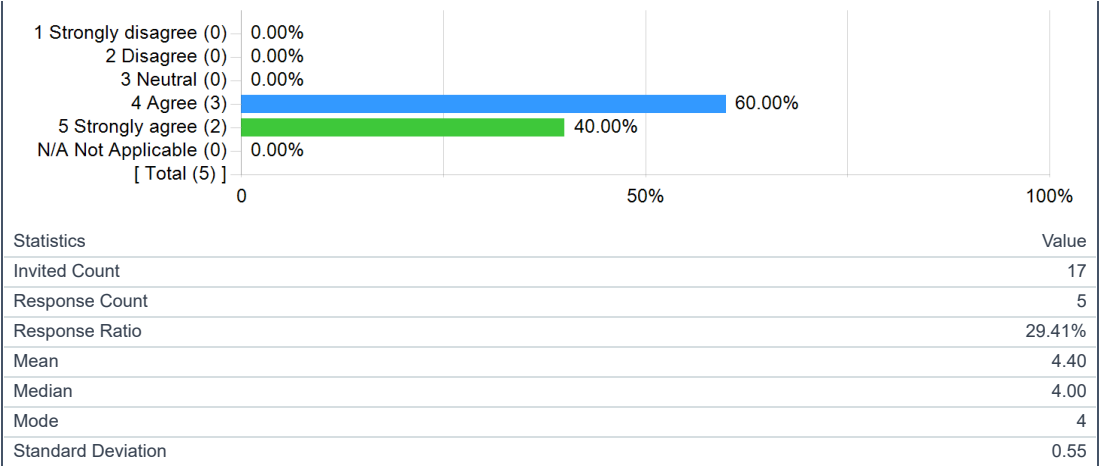
Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
I had the resources I needed to finish my coursework during the remote aspect of this course.	5	4.40	0.55

Instructor and Course Details

I was able to interact effectively with the instructor during the remote aspect of this course.

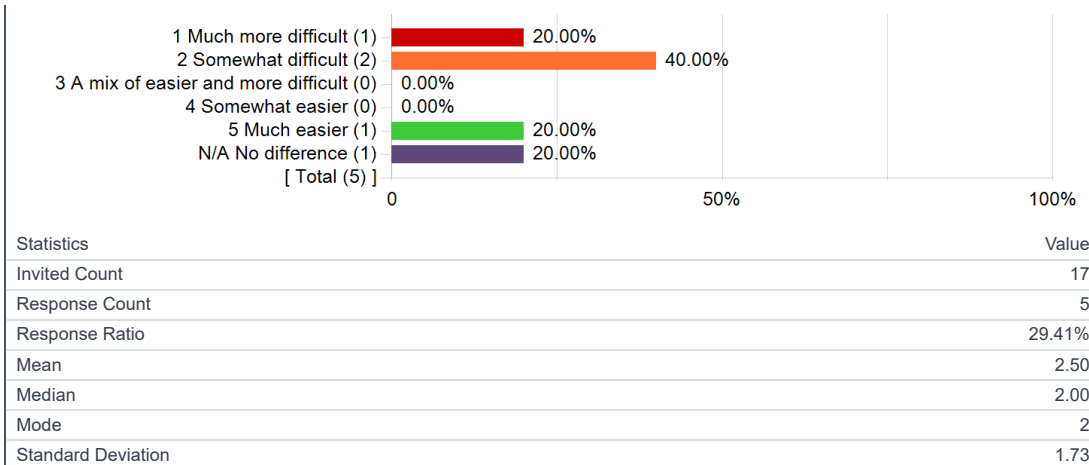


I had the resources I needed to finish my coursework during the remote aspect of this course.



Level of Difficulty

The remote aspect of this course made it (blank) for me to learn.



What do you think the University should know about your experience as a student in the current remote learning situation?

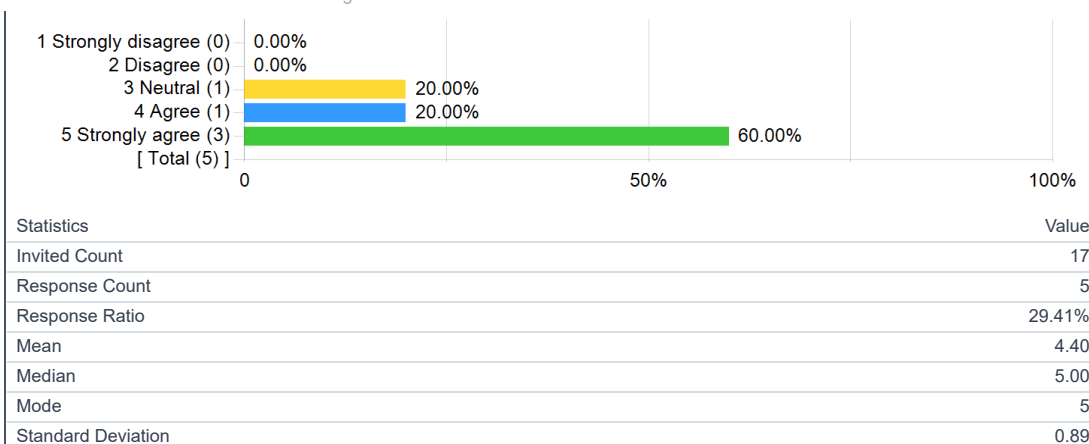
Students
As a student with a disability registered with DRS, remote learning has been incredibly helpful for me. I have been able to balance my time more easily between attending treatment while completing my assignments and attending classes. It has been so much easier for me to attend classes, since part of my disability made it difficult to physically reach certain classes on days where I would experience increasing hardships related to my illness.
Learning remotely has been harder
Hard to focus and absorb information
The way this course was taught remotely was done very well. There was nothing that hindered my learning ability.

Diversity and Inclusion

Question	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
The instructor creates an inclusive learning environment for all students.	5	4.40	0.89

Details

The instructor creates an inclusive learning environment for all students.





Spring 2021 - Yao Fan PHIL 0210 - HISTORY OF MODERN PHILOSOPHY - 1075 - Recitation

Project Title: 2214 - Teaching Survey Spring 2021

Courses Audience: 17
Responses Received: 8
Response Rate: 47.06%

Report Comments

Included in this report:

- Responses to numerical questions
- Responses to instructor added questions (if applicable)
- Student comments

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Creation Date: Thursday, May 20, 2021

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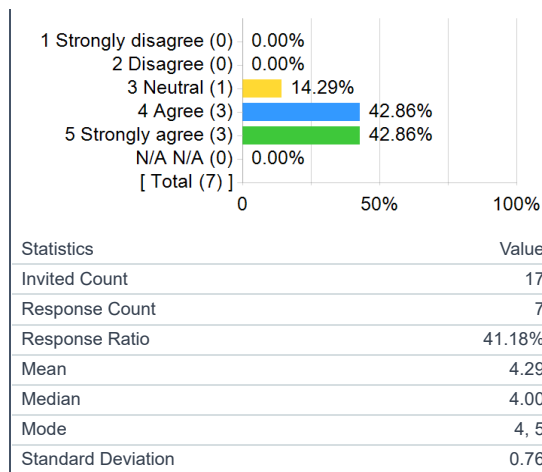
Recitation Questions

Summary: 5-point scale - Strongly Disagree to Strongly Agree

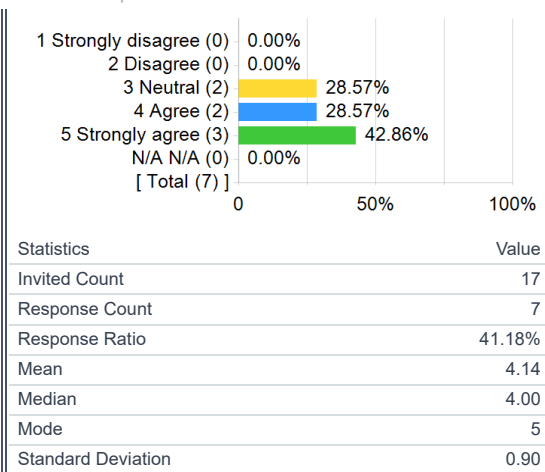
Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
The recitation instructor was prepared for recitation.	7	4.29	0.76
The recitation instructor used appropriate examples to clarify difficult concepts.	7	4.14	0.90
The recitation instructor was available to me (in-person, electronically, or both). If there is no basis to judge or not applicable, answer N/A.	8	4.13	0.83
The recitation enhanced my understanding of the class material.	8	4.13	0.83

Detailed Responses

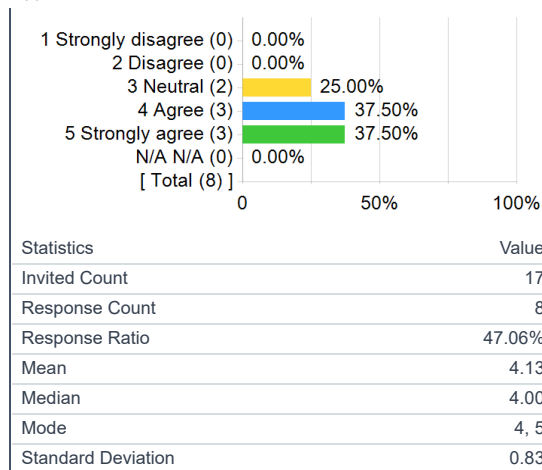
1. The recitation instructor was prepared for recitation.



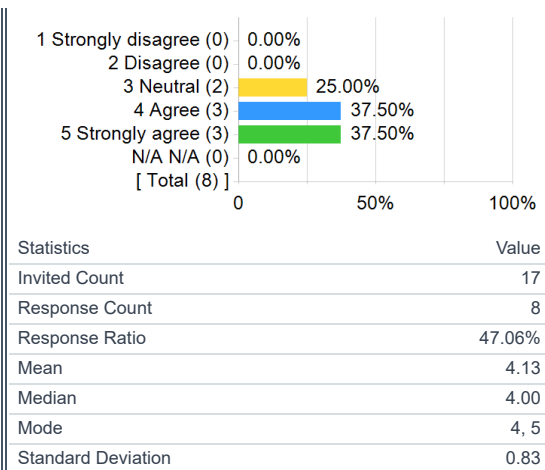
2. The recitation instructor used appropriate examples to clarify difficult concepts.



3. The recitation instructor was available to me (in-person, electronically, or both). If there is no basis to judge or not applicable, answer N/A.



4. The recitation enhanced my understanding of the class material.



Comments

What did you like best about the recitation instruction?

Comments

He really knew how to use the breakout rooms. Knowing this class was an elective for a lot of freshmen, he realized that he wasn't getting enough participation in the full group setting. I learned a lot in my discussion with my peers, and his review at the end of recitation was always a nice wrap-up.

There were questions to discuss

When we are put into groups, Yao would enter our group around three times in a recitation so whenever we were confused on an issue, we could ask him. I think this was very good because it helped me understand a lot more about the material.

The recitation provided a lot of clarity to the lectures especially since the lectures were very text-heavy and moved very quickly.

I really liked how he was able to simplify the difficult concepts from the reading and give many examples. Always willing to answer questions!

If you were running this recitation, what would you do differently?

Comments

Live by the breakout room, die by the breakout room. As a senior philosophy minor, I often felt the burden to carry the discussion of my breakout group, which limited how much I got out of recitation. By the end of the semester, I found myself skipping recitation a few times because the freshmen in the class weren't engaging in philosophical discussions in the way I've been accustomed to in my more advanced philosophy classes last term. This isn't a knock on Yao, more so the other students in the class. The only way to ameliorate this problem is course-wide. Treat the class as children and hold them accountable for being on top of the readings. Administer pop quizzes or force participation or reward it with extra credit. It's not something that should need to happen, but given my experiences in recitation it would definitely improve the learning environment.

instead of putting us in groups to discuss questions we should talk as a whole some things that we discussed alone were not accurate

I think that more time needed to be spent on answering the questions. We are usually spending the last 10 minutes of class to explain 4-6 questions which isn't enough time to explain everything. I think if we had 15 or 20 minutes saved for this, it would be better.

I would dedicate some time to re-explaining some of the major concepts of the lecture/reading section.

Maybe less time in breakout rooms and more of him talking/ explaining the concepts.

Remote Instruction and Learning Questions

Instructor Interaction

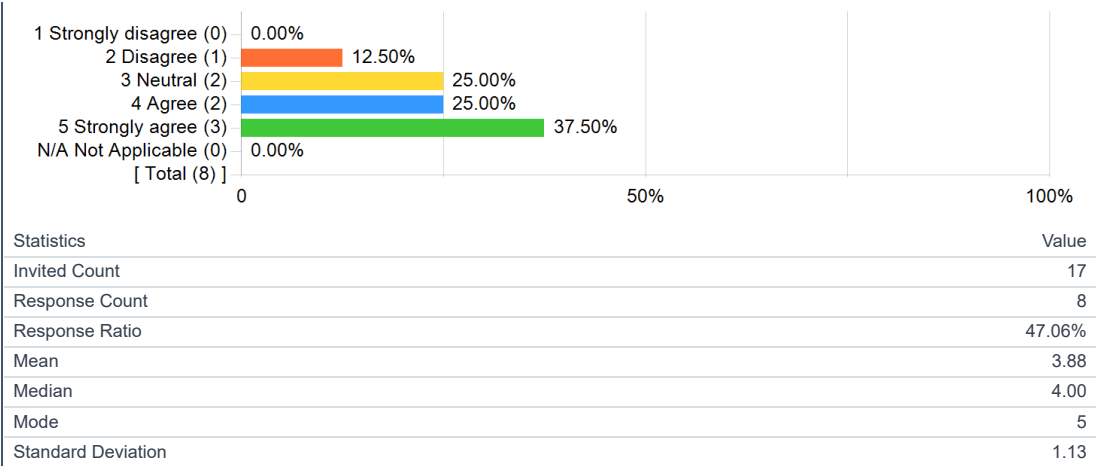
Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
I was able to interact effectively with the instructor during the remote aspect of this course.	8	3.88	1.13

Course Resources

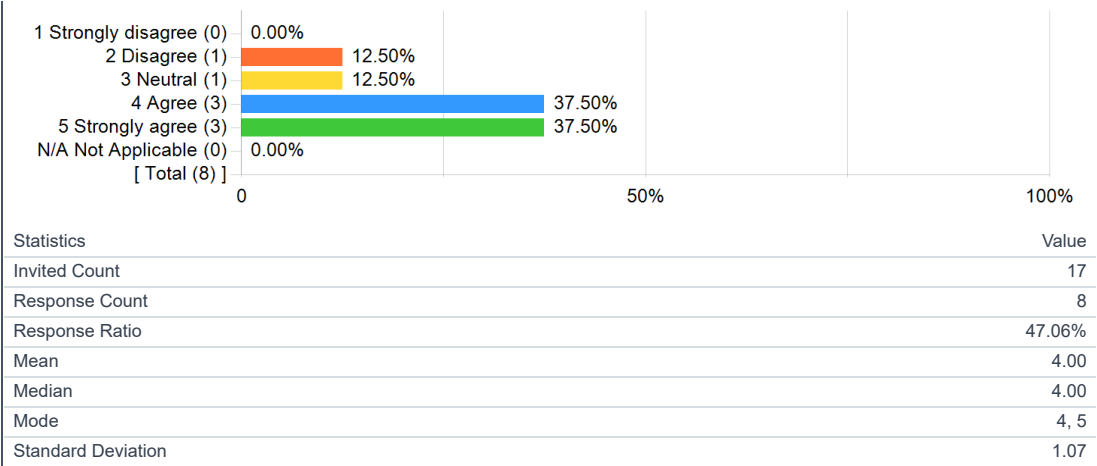
Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
I had the resources I needed to finish my coursework during the remote aspect of this course.	8	4.00	1.07

Instructor and Course Details

I was able to interact effectively with the instructor during the remote aspect of this course.

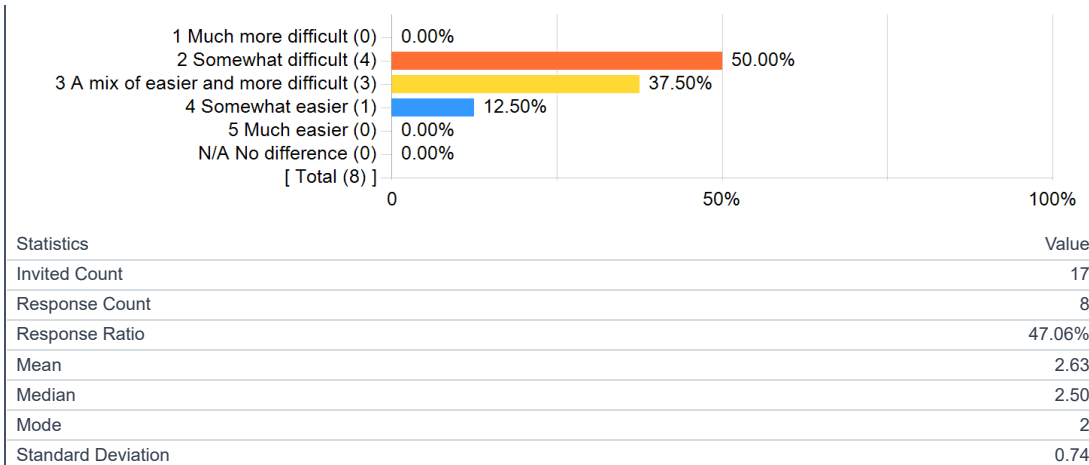


I had the resources I needed to finish my coursework during the remote aspect of this course.



Level of Difficulty

The remote aspect of this course made it (blank) for me to learn.



What do you think the University should know about your experience as a student in the current remote learning situation?

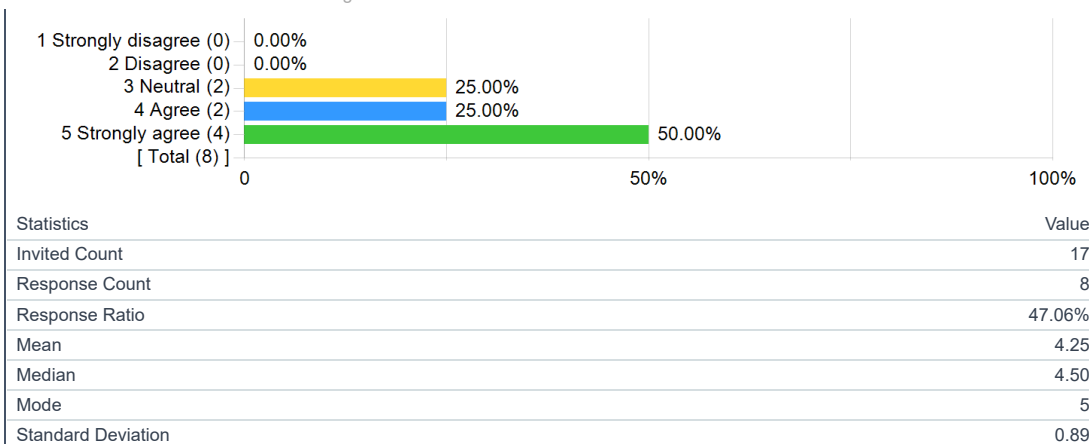
Students
Participation-based recitations in elective courses is much tougher. More work needs to be done to coax students to be more active in recitation.
I think a lot more effort is needed to make classes more engaging as with remote learning, motivation to attend and participate in class is easily the hardest part. This is usually made easier to deal with in in-person classes but remote learning can make 50 minutes of pure talking much less palatable.
Remote learning will never be as good as in-person classes. Although I understand their necessity, there is a certain aspect of the classroom experience that online learning can never have.

Diversity and Inclusion

Question	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
The instructor creates an inclusive learning environment for all students.	8	4.25	0.89

Details

The instructor creates an inclusive learning environment for all students.





Spring 2021 - Yao Fan PHIL 0210 - HISTORY OF MODERN PHILOSOPHY - 1080 - Recitation

Project Title: 2214 - Teaching Survey Spring 2021

Courses Audience: 19
Responses Received: 6
Response Rate: 31.58%

Report Comments

Included in this report:

- Responses to numerical questions
- Responses to instructor added questions (if applicable)
- Student comments

Interpreting OMET Teaching Survey Reports

A guide to interpreting OMET teaching survey results can be found here - <https://teaching.pitt.edu/omet/survey-results/>.

Develop a plan using your student opinion of teaching results.

- Meet with a Teaching Consultant who can help you interpret your results and develop a course of action if necessary. Email teaching@pitt.edu to set up a consultation.
- Plan on collecting student feedback during the semester the next time you teach. OMET offers a midterm course survey option and there are additional ways to collect student feedback throughout the term. For more information, go to <https://teaching.pitt.edu/omet/midterm/>
- In the future, discuss, teach, and model giving meaningful feedback with your students. Give them multiple opportunities to practice giving feedback. We have several resources that can help guide the discussion and options for gathering student feedback throughout the term.

Go to: <https://teaching.pitt.edu/omet/> for more details, references, and resources.

Creation Date: Thursday, May 20, 2021

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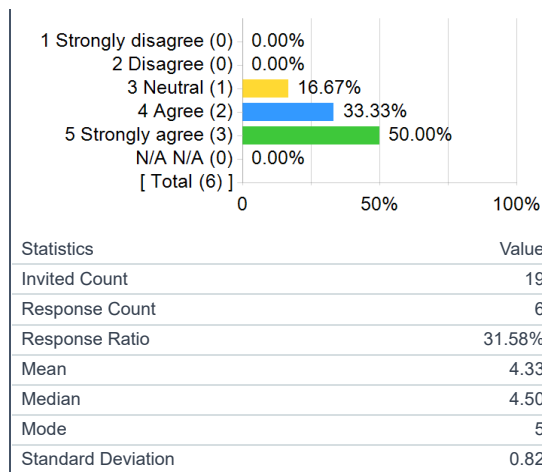
Recitation Questions

Summary: 5-point scale - Strongly Disagree to Strongly Agree

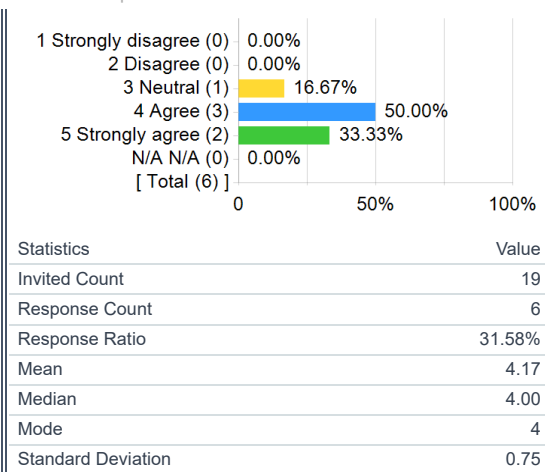
Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
The recitation instructor was prepared for recitation.	6	4.33	0.82
The recitation instructor used appropriate examples to clarify difficult concepts.	6	4.17	0.75
The recitation instructor was available to me (in-person, electronically, or both). If there is no basis to judge or not applicable, answer N/A.	6	4.67	0.52
The recitation enhanced my understanding of the class material.	6	4.00	1.55

Detailed Responses

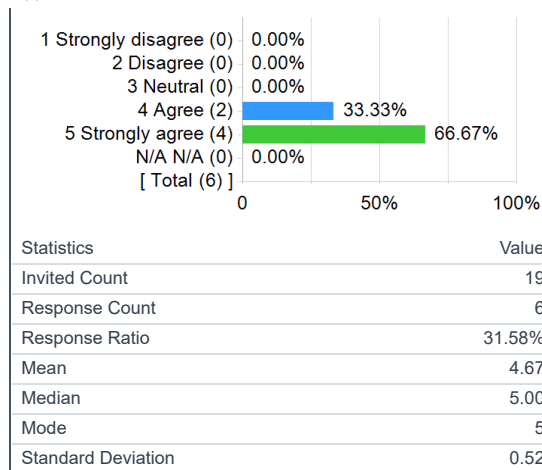
1. The recitation instructor was prepared for recitation.



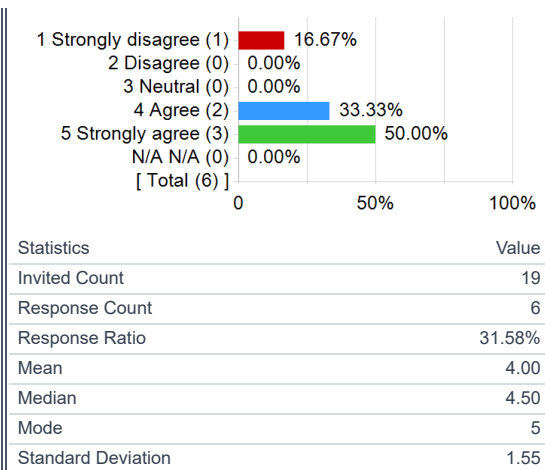
2. The recitation instructor used appropriate examples to clarify difficult concepts.



3. The recitation instructor was available to me (in-person, electronically, or both). If there is no basis to judge or not applicable, answer N/A.



4. The recitation enhanced my understanding of the class material.



Comments

What did you like best about the recitation instruction?

Comments
It was nice to just have to discuss a few questions and have a discussion with other students about material and that was helpful.
Yao always seemed happy to talk to the students and he really enjoyed the subject.
Yao was very open to questions and gave the best answers he could give!
Discussions questions were very good for prompting discussion between students and the instructor was very helpful in clarifying ideas that students were unsure of.
successful in clarifying the dense content of lectures and optimizing instruction towards assignments
It's so important to have the kind of discussion we had in recitation outside of lecture as a means to reinforce the material.

If you were running this recitation, what would you do differently?

Comments
Maybe give a small amount of time for assignment questions and exam review rather than just the questions all the time. I know other people in a different recitation and i used the info their TA gave to help them on the assignments.
I would maybe alternate every week between different activities, as in do small-group discussions one week, and then something else the next.
not sure
run fewer breakout rooms
I don't think I would have done anything differently !

Remote Instruction and Learning Questions

Instructor Interaction

Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
I was able to interact effectively with the instructor during the remote aspect of this course.	6	4.33	0.52

Course Resources

Question	Results		
	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
I had the resources I needed to finish my coursework during the remote aspect of this course.	6	4.50	0.55

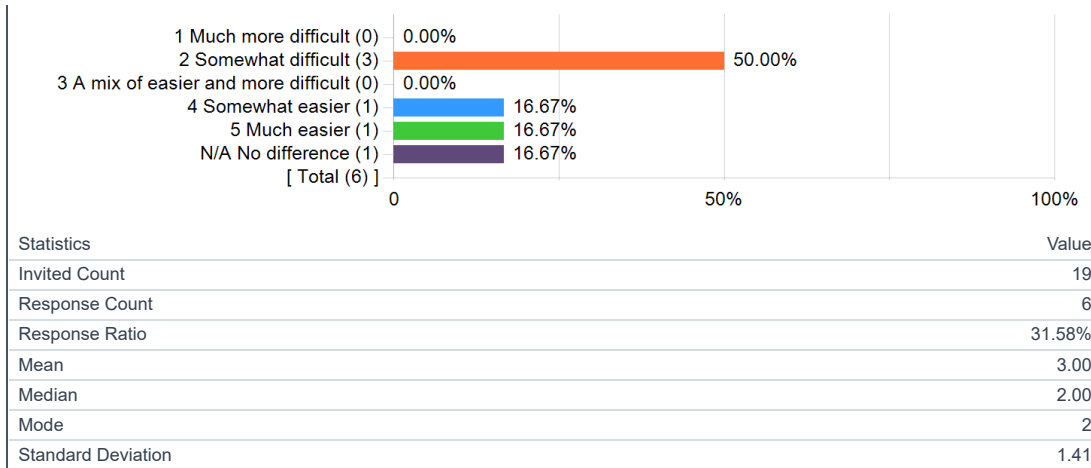
Instructor and Course Details

I was able to interact effectively with the instructor during the remote aspect of this course.	
1 Strongly disagree (0) 2 Disagree (0) 3 Neutral (0) 4 Agree (4) 5 Strongly agree (2) N/A Not Applicable (0) [Total (6)] 0.00% 0.00% 0.00% 66.67% 33.33% 0.00%	
Statistics	Value
Invited Count	19
Response Count	6
Response Ratio	31.58%
Mean	4.33
Median	4.00
Mode	4
Standard Deviation	0.52

I had the resources I needed to finish my coursework during the remote aspect of this course.	
1 Strongly disagree (0) 2 Disagree (0) 3 Neutral (0) 4 Agree (3) 5 Strongly agree (3) N/A Not Applicable (0) [Total (6)] 0.00% 0.00% 0.00% 50.00% 50.00% 0.00%	
Statistics	Value
Invited Count	19
Response Count	6
Response Ratio	31.58%
Mean	4.50
Median	4.50
Mode	4, 5
Standard Deviation	0.55

Level of Difficulty

The remote aspect of this course made it (blank) for me to learn.



What do you think the University should know about your experience as a student in the current remote learning situation?

Students

we didn't get a vacation and were forced to do 15 uninterrupted weeks of zoom.

Nothing to report. I am lucky enough to do well as a remote learning student.

Diversity and Inclusion

Question	Response Count	Mean	Standard Deviation
The instructor creates an inclusive learning environment for all students.	6	4.67	0.52

Details

The instructor creates an inclusive learning environment for all students.

